United Kingdom — Emergency Reference

What the government plans, and what to do, when the internet is down

2026-10-26

- United Kingdom — Emergency Reference
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United Kingdom — Emergency Reference

> **This document assumes the internet is unavailable.** It summarises what the UK government, devolved administrations and local responders have planned and advised, as of 26 October 2026. If official instructions (radio, TV, Emergency Alert, emergency services) differ from this document, **follow the official instruction**.

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A. QUICK REFERENCE (first pages — print separately)

A.1 First 5 minutes

1. **Get inside.** Close windows and doors; if there is smoke, gas or a chemical release, shut off ventilation and block gaps.[1]
2. **Tune in.** BBC local radio or BBC Radio 4 on a battery or wind-up FM radio. Write the frequency on the radio now.[2]
3. **Check your phone.** A UK Emergency Alert stays on screen; read the whole message.
4. **Warn and help your neighbours** — especially anyone frail, alone, disabled or not fluent in English.
5. **Stay in until it is safe.** Follow the emergency services; do not go and look.

> **“Go in, stay in, tune in.”** That is the official UK advice for most incidents — unless there is an obvious danger to the building (fire, structural damage), going inside and listening for instructions is usually the safest action.[3]

A.2 Emergency numbers

Service	Number	Notes
Emergency (police, fire, ambulance, coastguard, mountain rescue)	**999**	Also **112** — both work, and both reach the same control rooms.
Police, non-emergency	**101**	
NHS non-emergency medical help	**111**	Free, 24/7.
Power cut	**105**	England, Scotland and Wales. Northern Ireland: **03457 643643**.
Gas emergency (smell gas)	**0800 111 999**	Free, 24/7.
Environment Agency incident hotline	**0800 80 70 60**	Pollution, flooding of rivers/sea, dead animals.
Floodline	**0345 988 1188**	Textphone **0345 602 6340**; 24-hour.
Samaritans	**116 123**	Free, 24/7, any phone.
NHS mental health crisis	**111**, then **option 2**	
Poisoning advice	**111** (or 999 if severe)	The National Poisons Information Service advises clinicians, not the public.

[VERIFY each number on the operator's own page before print — see the notes.]

A.3 Warnings and alerting

Signal	What it looks like	Meaning	What you do
UK Emergency Alert	Loud siren-like sound, vibration, full-screen text on your phone or tablet	The government or emergency services are warning you about a danger to life nearby	Read the whole message; follow its instructions; tell others
Emergency Alert test	Same sound, message says it is a test	Test only	Nothing
Flood alert (orange triangle, one wavy line)	Issued by the Environment Agency	Flooding is **possible** — prepare	Be ready to act; check your flood plan; move livestock and equipment
Flood warning (red triangle, two wavy lines)	Environment Agency	Flooding is **expected** — act now	Move people, pets and valuables to safety; go to higher ground or an upper floor; turn off gas, electricity and water if safe
Severe flood warning (red triangle, three wavy lines)	Environment Agency	Flooding **could risk life** and cause significant disruption	Stay in a safe place; be ready to evacuate; call 999 if in immediate danger
Met Office warning: yellow / amber / red	Weather forecast and app	Yellow: be aware. Amber: increased likelihood of impacts. Red: dangerous weather, risk to life — act now	Read the detail; change plans; avoid travel in red
BBC local radio / Radio 4	Radio	Official emergency information	Keep listening; this is your most reliable source when power and internet fail
Door-to-door / loudhailer	Police, fire or council	Local evacuation or instruction	Follow it immediately

How Emergency Alerts work. Mobile masts in the affected area broadcast the alert; every compatible phone or tablet in range receives it. It does **not** need mobile data or wifi, it is **free**, and you do **not** sign up. It runs on **4G and 5G** networks. You will **not** receive it if your device is turned off, connected to a 2G or 3G network, wifi-only, or incompatible; you *may not* receive it in airplane mode. Compatible: **iPhone iOS 14.5 or later**, **Android 11 or later**. Your phone number and location are **not** collected. [4]

A.4 Radio and TV for official information

Battery or wind-up **FM radio** is the most reliable channel when power, internet and mobile networks fail. Write your local frequencies on the radio now.

Medium	Station	What it gives you	Notes
FM	**BBC Radio 4**	National news and emergency information	The UK's emergency broadcaster of record
FM / DAB	**BBC local radio** (England)	County/regional information, travel, local instructions	~39 stations; see the list in Appendix 4
FM / DAB	**BBC Radio Scotland, Radio Wales, Radio Cymru, Radio Ulster / Foyle**	Devolved-nation information	Scotland, Wales, Northern Ireland
FM	**BBC Radio 5 Live**	Rolling national news	
FM	**Commercial and community radio**	Local travel and information	Many carry local emergency messages
DAB+	All BBC and most commercial stations	Same content, better sound	Needs power; less useful in a blackout
TV	**BBC One / ITV / Channel 4 / Channel 5**	Public information broadcasts	Fails when power or transmission fails
Longwave	**BBC Radio 4 on 198 kHz**	National coverage from a single transmitter	Longwave still carries Radio 4; check whether your radio receives it [VERIFY: longwave has been discussed for closure]

Why radio: Emergency Alerts need a 4G or 5G mast, and TV needs power and a signal. A radio on batteries or a dynamo needs neither. [5]

Write these on your radio now: your BBC local radio frequency, BBC Radio 4 on FM, and the frequency of any community station for your area.

A.5 Household emergency card (fill in by hand)

Item	Value
Household members, medical needs, medication and doses	
Out-of-area contact (name, phone, address)	
Meeting point — near home	
Meeting point — outside the neighbourhood	
Nearest rest centre / community hub	
Nearest hospital with emergency department	
Evacuation routes from home and from the area	
Gas meter/ECV, water stopcock, electricity consumer unit locations	
GP, pharmacy, vet	
Insurance policy numbers	

Notes

1. https://beready.campaign.gov.uk/be-informed-about-hazards/ — "go in, stay in, tune in"; seek shelter in most incidents. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
2. https://beready.campaign.gov.uk/be-ready-for-emergencies/ — keep a battery or wind-up FM radio and write down the frequencies of national and local stations used for news. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑

3. https://beready.campaign.gov.uk/be-informed-about-hazards/ — unless there is an obvious risk to a building, going inside and seeking information is often the safest action. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
4. https://www.gov.uk/alerts/how-alerts-work — alerts are broadcast from mobile masts; no data or wifi needed; free and no sign-up; 4G and 5G only; will not arrive if the device is off, on 2G/3G, wifi-only or incompatible; iPhone iOS 14.5+ or Android 11+; no phone number or location collected. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
5. https://beready.campaign.gov.uk/be-ready-for-emergencies/ — for updates during outages, write down the frequencies of the national and local radio stations you use for news; a battery or wind-up FM radio is part of the official kit. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑

B. HOW THE UK IS ORGANISED FOR CRISES

B.1 Overview: who does what

Level	Body	Role
National (political)	**COBR** — Cabinet Office Briefing Rooms	Cross-government crisis meeting, chaired by the Prime Minister or a senior minister, convened for significant national emergencies
National (coordination)	**Civil Contingencies Secretariat** (Cabinet Office)	Coordinates cross-government resilience, owns the National Risk Register, supports COBR
National (lead)	**Lead Government Department (LGD)**	The department that leads the response for a given risk (e.g. flooding → Defra/ Environment Agency; health → DHSC/ UKHSA; energy → DESNZ)
Regional (England)	**Local Resilience Forum (LRF)**	Multi-agency planning and response body for a police area, built on the Civil Contingencies Act 2004
Regional (Scotland)	**Regional Resilience Partnership (RRP)**	Scottish equivalent of the LRF
Regional (Wales)	**Local Resilience Forum (Wales)**	Four LRFs in Wales
Regional (NI)	**Emergency Preparedness Group (EPG)**	Northern Ireland equivalent
Local	**Local authority, police, fire, ambulance, NHS, Environment Agency**	Category 1 responders with statutory duties
Local (voluntary)	Red Cross, St John Ambulance, RNLI, mountain rescue, search and rescue	Category 2 responders and volunteers

B.2 The Civil Contingencies Act 2004

The Act has two parts with very different consequences for you.

Part 1 — local responders' duties. It defines an "emergency" as an event or situation that threatens serious damage to human welfare, to the environment, or (in the case of war or terrorism) to the security of the United Kingdom. Damage to human welfare specifically includes loss of life, illness or injury, homelessness, damage to property, disruption of supplies of money, food, water, energy or fuel, disruption of communication systems, disruption of transport, and disruption of health services.[1]

It creates two categories of responder:

- **Category 1** (core duties): local authorities, police, fire and rescue authorities, ambulance services, NHS bodies, the Environment Agency and (in Wales) Natural Resources Wales. They must assess risk, plan, maintain business continuity, warn and inform the public, and share information.
- **Category 2** (cooperating responders): utilities, transport operators, telephone providers, health and safety regulators and others. They must cooperate and share information.

Every LRF publishes a **Community Risk Register** for its area — the local version of the National Risk Register.

Part 2 — emergency powers. This is the part that can change your legal rights, and it has deliberate safeguards, often called the “triple lock”:

1. An emergency has occurred, is occurring or is about to occur;
2. it is necessary to make provision to prevent, control or mitigate an aspect or effect of it;
3. the need for that provision is **urgent**. [3]

Emergency regulations can be made by Order in Council, or by a senior minister (the Prime Minister or a Secretary of State) if waiting for an Order in Council would cause serious delay. [2]

Hard limits on emergency regulations:

- They may only be made so far as is **appropriate** to the emergency and **in due proportion** to its effects.
- They must state which parts of the UK they apply to.
- They **cannot require anyone to provide military service**.
- They **cannot prohibit participation in a strike** or other industrial action.
- They cannot create serious criminal offences: any offence must be triable only summarily, with a maximum of **3 months’ imprisonment** or a level 5 fine.
- They **cannot amend Part 2 of the Act itself or the Human Rights Act 1998**. [4]

Duration: emergency regulations **lapse after 30 days** unless made again sooner. Lapsing does not undo anything already done under them, and new regulations can be made. [5]

What this means in practice: the UK has no standing “state of emergency” that suspends normal law. Emergency powers are temporary, proportionate, time-limited and cannot touch the Human Rights Act. Parliament is recalled and the regulations are scrutinised.

B.3 National risk planning

The **National Risk Register (NRR)** is the public version of the government’s classified National Security Risk Assessment. The current edition is **NRR 2026**, published on **12 August 2026**, superseding NRR 2025 (16 January 2025); the NSRA now runs as a “dynamic assessment process” with risks reassessed more often. [6]

The register contains **87 standalone risks plus 8 linked scenarios — 95 risks in total**.[13] [15]

For each risk the NRR sets out a **reasonable worst-case scenario** — not a prediction, but the worst plausible manifestation once highly unlikely variations are discounted. [7]

Risk areas covered include terrorism (including CBRN and attacks on infrastructure), cyber attacks on energy, health, transport, telecoms and finance, state threats, disruption to gas and oil supplies, accidents and systems failures (including reservoir or dam collapse and loss of drinking water), natural hazards (wildfire, volcanic eruption, earthquake, severe space weather, storms, heatwaves, low temperatures, coastal, fluvial and surface-water flooding, drought, poor air quality), and human, animal and plant health (pandemic, emerging infectious disease, foot and mouth disease). [8]

The most significant risks in 2026: a pandemic (“disease X”, catastrophic impact, 5–25% likelihood); **water infrastructure failure or loss of drinking water** (impact raised to catastrophic); **national power outage**; **national gas and electricity shortfall**; conflict and global instability; terrorist and state threats including CBRN; digital failure; space-based services; flooding (coastal, fluvial and surface water); low temperatures and snow; heatwaves; and cyber attacks. About **6.3 million properties in England** lie in areas at flood risk from one or more sources. [14] [16]

What changed in 2026. The NRR 2026 adds, among others:

- **digital resilience failure** — based on lessons from the CrowdStrike IT outage of July 2024;
- **cyber attack on water infrastructure** — following reported attacks on the water sector;

- **two data-infrastructure risks** (a cyber attack and a disruption) — the sector became a critical national infrastructure sub-sector in 2024;
- **interference in democratic processes**;
- **significant disruption to the criminal justice system**; and
- **accidental damage to the national gas transmission network**.

Scoring was also adjusted for some existing risks. The NSRA now updates risks "as frequently as needed", and a refreshed Expert Advisory Programme is used to challenge "groupthink". [9] [10]

Announcements alongside the 2026 edition included a national public awareness campaign, a formalised role for regional mayors in local resilience under a consultation on the Civil Contingencies Act 2004, and the largest UK home defence exercise in decades — **Exercise ALBISTON SHADOW** — planned for 2027 to test hybrid attacks.[11]

The NRR is written for responders and businesses. Household advice sits separately on **GOV.UK/Prepare** and the **Be Ready** campaign, and each LRF's Community Risk Register is the local picture.[12]

B.4 Local resilience

- **Local Resilience Forums (LRFs)** are the multi-agency planning bodies for each police area in England and Wales. They bring together councils, emergency services, the NHS, the Environment Agency and utilities to plan for and respond to local emergencies.
- **Scotland** uses **Regional Resilience Partnerships**; **Northern Ireland** uses **Emergency Preparedness Groups**. These play the same convening role as LRFs. [7]
- LRFs publish **Community Risk Registers** identifying the highest-priority risks in their area. Your LRF's register is the most relevant risk document for your street.
- In a live incident the response is coordinated through the police (who normally chair the multi-agency "gold" command) unless the incident is led by another agency — for example the Environment Agency for flooding of main rivers, or a local authority for rest centres.

B.5 Emergency services

Service	Structure	How to reach it
Police	43 territorial forces in England and Wales, plus **Police Scotland** and the **PSNI**, plus national agencies (NCA, BTP, MoD Police)	**999** emergency, **101** non-emergency
Fire and rescue	Separate services per nation — 44 in England (fire and rescue authorities), one in Scotland (SFRS), three in Wales, one in Northern Ireland (NIFRS). [VERIFY counts]	**999**
Ambulance	England: regional **NHS ambulance trusts**; **Scottish Ambulance Service**; **Welsh Ambulance Service**; **Northern Ireland Ambulance Service**	**999** for life-threatening; **111** for urgent non-emergency
NHS 111	Urgent care advice, out-of-hours GP, dental, mental health triage	**111**, free, 24/7; **111 online**
HM Coastguard	Maritime and coastal search and rescue, part of the Maritime and Coastguard Agency	**999** and ask for the Coastguard
RNLI	Independent charity lifeboat service, 238 stations around the UK and Ireland [VERIFY]	**999** and ask for the Coastguard
Mountain rescue	Volunteer teams in England, Wales and Scotland; **Mountain Rescue Ireland** in NI	**999** and ask for Police, then Mountain Rescue
Lowland rescue, cave rescue, search dogs	Volunteer search and rescue	**999**
Air ambulance	Charitable, regionally funded	Via **999**

Important: calling 999 does **not** guarantee an ambulance. For non-life-threatening problems you may be advised to make your own way to an urgent treatment centre or emergency department, or to call 111 first. Call 999 only for a genuine emergency. [15]

B.6 Military and civil defence

- The UK has **no conscription**. The National Service Act 1948 introduced post-war national service; the last national servicemen were discharged in **1963**, and the legal basis for peacetime conscription no longer exists. There is currently **no legal mechanism** to conscript people into the armed forces. [VERIFY: current legislative position]
- Military support to civil authorities is called **MACA** — Military Aid to the Civil Authorities. It covers **MACC** (civil authorities, e.g. flood defences), **MAGD** (government departments) and **MCPA** (the police, including counter-terrorism). It is provided on request, is normally temporary, and is paid for by the requesting authority where a statutory duty exists.
- The **Armed Forces reserves** can be called out under the Reserve Forces Act 1996 for national danger, warlike operations and certain other purposes.
- The UK's **nuclear deterrent** is **Trident**, based on four Vanguard-class submarines at HM Naval Base Clyde (Faslane), with Trident II D5 missiles and warheads from the Atomic Weapons Establishment. The "continuous at-sea deterrent" means at least one boat is deployed at all times.
- The UK is a founding **NATO** member. NATO Article 5 — an attack on one is an attack on all — has been invoked once, after the attacks of 11 September 2001.
- **Nuclear war planning:** the UK maintains a **Standing Defence Nuclear Command** arrangement so that constitutional authority to act survives a decapitation strike. Letters of last resort are written by each Prime Minister. [VERIFY: current arrangements]

B.7 How the government will communicate with you

In order of reliability when the internet fails:

1. **Emergency Alert** — cell broadcast to your phone; no data, no signup, works under network load.
2. **BBC local radio and BBC Radio 4** — the designated emergency broadcasters; they stay on air during power outages.
3. **TV and social media** — only while power, transmission and internet survive.
4. **Door-to-door and loudhailer** — police, fire and council at street level.
5. **Rest centres and community hubs** — physical information points.

Recognising a genuine message:

- An Emergency Alert is a full-screen message with a siren-like sound, giving the area, the agency that sent it, what is happening, and what to do. It is also published on **GOV.UK/alerts**.
- The government will **never** ask for money, passwords or bank details by alert, text or email.
- Check a second source: BBC local radio or the emergency services' social media.
- Do not forward unverified messages. Misinformation spreads fastest in the first hours. [16]

Notes

1. Civil Contingencies Act 2004, Part 1, s.1 — definition of "emergency", including the list of harms to human welfare. https://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukpga/2004/36/part/1. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
2. Civil Contingencies Act 2004, s.20 — who may make emergency regulations. https://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukpga/2004/36/section/20. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
3. Civil Contingencies Act 2004, s.21 — the three conditions ("triple lock"). https://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukpga/2004/36/section/21. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
4. Civil Contingencies Act 2004, s.23 — proportionality, geographical scope, prohibitions (no military service, no ban on industrial action), offence limits, and the bar on amending Part 2 or the Human Rights Act 1998. https://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukpga/2004/36/section/23. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑

5. Civil Contingencies Act 2004, s.26 — emergency regulations lapse after 30 days. https://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukpga/2004/36/section/26. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
6. National Risk Register 2026 — publication page, Cabinet Office, published 12 August 2026. https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/national-risk-register-2026. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
7. National Risk Register 2026, PDF — “reasonable worst-case scenario” method and the risk summaries (terrorism, cyber, state threats, accidents, natural hazards, health). https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/6a50d66b1228eb26a4cab76c/National_Risk_Register_2026.pdf. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
8. National Risk Register 2026, PDF, Chapter 3 and introduction — Community Risk Registers, Local Resilience Forums, Regional Resilience Partnerships and Emergency Preparedness Groups in Northern Ireland. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
9. National Risk Register 2026, PDF, “What are the key changes in this edition?” — digital resilience failure, cyber attack on water infrastructure, two data-infrastructure risks, interference in democratic processes, disruption to the criminal justice system, and accidental damage to the national gas transmission network. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
10. National Risk Register 2026, PDF, introduction — the NSRA as a dynamic assessment process updated as frequently as needed, and the refreshed Expert Advisory Programme. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
11. https://www.gov.uk/government/news/risk-of-democratic-interference-added-to-national-risk-register — seven new risks, the resilience campaign, the mayors consultation on the Civil Contingencies Act 2004, and Exercise ALBISTON SHADOW in 2027. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
12. https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/national-risk-register-2026 — the NRR is aimed at practitioners; household information is on GOV.UK/Prepare; local risks are in each Community Risk Register. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
13. https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/6a50d66b1228eb26a4cab76c/National_Risk_Register_2026.pdf — 87 standalone risks plus 8 linked scenarios (95 risks) in the 2026 edition. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
14. https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/6a7c4412aadaaddf89b6e484/A_Guide_to_the_2026_National_Risk_Register.pdf — most significant 2026 risks: pandemic (disease X, catastrophic, 5–25% likelihood), water infrastructure failure with impact raised to catastrophic, national power outage, national gas and electricity shortfall, conflict and global instability, terrorist and state threats including CBRN, digital failure, space-based services, flooding, low temperatures, heatwaves and cyber; about 6.3 million properties in England at flood risk. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑

C. SCENARIOS

C.1 Flooding (coastal, river, surface water, reservoir)

C.1.1 Risk in the UK

- Flooding is one of the UK’s most significant natural hazards and appears three times in the National Risk Register: **coastal**, **fluvial** and **surface water** flooding. [1]
- The NRR’s reasonable worst-case coastal scenario is flooding across the **east coast of England**, affecting a very large number of homes, with comprehensive warnings, mass evacuation and shelter, fatalities and casualties, and large areas of road and rail flooded. [2]
- **Scale (England, 31 March 2026): 2,422,000** properties are at risk from rivers or the sea and **4,547,600** from surface water. Surface water carries the bigger high-risk population — **1,014,100** properties at high risk versus **319,700** from rivers and sea. That is about **1 in 5** properties at risk today, rising towards **1 in 4** by the middle of the century. [37]
- Sea level rise increases coastal risk over time. Surface-water (“flash”) flooding can happen anywhere, not only near a river, and is **not** covered by Environment Agency flood warnings. [3]
- **Rapid response catchments** are rivers so responsive to heavy rain that they can flash flood **before any warning can be issued**. If you live in one, the first sign may be the flood itself. [38]

What has happened before:

Event	Impact
1953 North Sea flood (31 Jan–1 Feb)	**307 dead in England, 19 in Scotland**; over 2,500 dead around the North Sea; 24,500 homes damaged or destroyed in England; 30,000+ evacuated. Led to the Thames Barrier and the Storm Tide Warning Service
Summer 2007	**55,000 properties** flooded, **13 dead**, about 7,000 rescued; the Mythe water works outage left **350,000 people without mains water for up to 17 days**; cost about **£3.2 billion**. Led to the Pitt Review and the Flood Forecasting Centre
Somerset 2013–14	Wettest winter for 250 years; about **150 km²** under water for weeks; **165 homes** flooded; cost up to **£147.5 million**
Storm Desmond, 5–6 Dec 2015	UK 24-hour rainfall record **341.4 mm** at Honister Pass; 6,421 homes and businesses flooded; 2 deaths; Carlisle worst hit
Storm Henk, Jan 2024	About **2,500 properties** flooded and **102,000 protected** by defences
2025–26 season	Storms Éowyn, Amy, Claudia, Goretti and Chandra; about **540 properties** flooded and **60,000 protected**

[39] [40] [37]

Defences that matter: - **Thames Barrier** spans **520 m** with **10 steel gates** of 3,300 tonnes each, protecting **125 km²** of central London, **1.42 million people** and about **£321 billion** of residential property. It has closed for flood defence **221 times** since 1982 (119 tidal, 102 combined) and its design life has been extended to **2070**. There is **no fixed trigger level**: a decision matrix plus the Duty Controller decides.[41] - **Hull** recorded its highest tide ever, **5.8 m**, on 5 December 2013. - **Boston Barrier** has been operational since **December 2020**, can be raised in about **40 minutes**, and reduces risk to **13,000+** homes and businesses.[39]

C.1.2 Official plan

- **England:** the **Environment Agency** issues flood warnings for rivers, the sea and groundwater and maintains defences on main rivers and the coast; **lead local flood authorities** (county and unitary councils) lead on surface water and ordinary watercourses; **internal drainage boards** manage low-lying land.
- **Wales: Natural Resources Wales**. **Scotland: SEPA**. **Northern Ireland: DAERA**.
- **Evacuation** is ordered by the police or the local authority, normally through multi-agency “gold” command. Rest centres and emergency accommodation are arranged by the local council.
- **Warning lead times:** a flood alert is normally issued **2 to 12 hours** before flooding; a flood warning **30 minutes to 2 hours** before.[3]

C.1.3 Warning

Level	Meaning	What you do
Flood alert (orange triangle, one wavy line)	Flooding is **possible** — prepare	Check your flood plan; have insurance documents and medication ready; move livestock and equipment; avoid flood water
Flood warning (red triangle, two wavy lines)	Flooding is **expected** — act now	Move people, pets and valuables to safety; go to higher ground or an upper floor; turn off gas, electricity and water if safe; deploy flood protection; follow the emergency services
Severe flood warning (red triangle, three wavy lines)	Flooding **could risk life** and cause significant community disruption	Stay in a safe place; be ready to evacuate; call **999** if in immediate danger; if caught in a flash flood, get to higher ground or an upper floor

[3]

Sign up: free flood warnings by phone, text or email for England (rivers, sea and groundwater — **not** surface water). By phone through **Floodline 0345 988 1188** (textphone 0345 602 6340), 24 hours.[4]

Early signs: water rising fast in a river or stream; the sound of rushing water; water coming out of drains; cracks, seepage or collapse at the foot of an embankment; sewage backing up.

C.1.4 Before

- Check your long-term flood risk (rivers, sea, surface water, reservoirs, groundwater) and the 5-day flood forecast.[3]
- **Make a flood plan** — personal, community/group or business. [5]
- Know how to turn off your gas, electricity and water. [6]
- Move valuables, electrical items and documents upstairs or into waterproof containers.
- Get flood protection: floodgates, air-brick covers, non-return valves, sandbags.
- Check your insurance covers flood (see G.4 — **Flood Re** matters here).
- Keep a **grab bag** by the door.
- Identify your nearest **community hub**, rest centre and higher ground.
- Find local support: **flood action groups**, **community flood wardens** and **community hubs** offering food, clothing, shelter and advice during a flood. [5]

C.1.5 During

If you are told to evacuate: 1. Leave immediately. Delaying or refusing to evacuate may put your life, and responders' lives, at risk.[7] 2. Turn off gas, electricity and water if it is safe. 3. Take your grab bag, medication, documents, phone and charger. 4. Do not walk, cycle or drive through flood water. 5. Follow the route the emergency services give you. 6. Tell a neighbour or leave a note saying where you have gone.

If you cannot leave: 1. Go to the highest floor; take water, food, medication, a torch and a radio. 2. Do not go into a cellar or basement. 3. Call **999** if your life is in danger. 4. Signal from a window so rescuers can see you. 5. If caught by a flash flood outdoors, move to higher ground immediately.

Never drive through flood water — it is often deeper and faster than it looks, and manhole covers can be missing.

C.1.6 After

- Do not return home until the authorities say it is safe.
- Assume flood water is contaminated with sewage: wear gloves and boots, wash hands, cover cuts.
- Photograph all damage **before** moving anything, for insurance.
- Throw away food that has touched flood water; use bottled water until told otherwise.
- Gas and electricity must be checked by a qualified engineer before reconnection.
- Contact your council about emergency accommodation if your home is uninhabitable. [8]
- Beware of damp, mould, electrical hazards and hidden structural damage.

C.1.7 Where to go

- **Rest centres** and emergency accommodation — arranged by your local council.
- **Community hubs** — food, clothing, shelter and advice during a flood. [5]
- Higher ground, or an upper floor of a sturdy building.
- Family or friends outside the flood area if you can travel safely.

C.1.8 Checklist

- ☐ Long-term flood risk checked for my address
- ☐

- [ ] Signed up for free flood warnings (Floodline 0345 988 1188)
- [ ] Flood plan written and discussed
- [ ] Know how to turn off gas, electricity and water
- [ ] Flood protection in place or planned
- [ ] Insurance checked, including flood cover
- [ ] Grab bag packed and by the door
- [ ] Valuables and documents moved upstairs
- [ ] Nearest community hub and rest centre identified
- [ ] Neighbours who need help identified

C.2 Severe weather (storms, heat, cold, snow, drought)

C.2.1 Risk in the UK

Storms, heatwaves, low temperatures and snow, drought and poor air quality each appear as separate risks in the National Risk Register 2026.[1] The Be Ready campaign was launched partly because “storms last winter and the wildfires this summer” showed how severe weather disrupts power, water, phones and the internet. [9]

C.2.2 Official plan

The **Met Office** issues UK weather warnings in three colours:

Colour	Meaning
Yellow	Be aware. Issued for a range of situations — read the detail
Amber	Increased likelihood of impacts: travel delays, road and rail closures, power cuts, risk to life and property
Red	Dangerous weather expected — take action now. Very likely a risk to life, with substantial disruption to travel and energy supplies, and possibly widespread damage

[10]

Warnings are judged on both **likelihood** (e.g. “high, 50–75%”) and **impact**, and the Met Office advises being prepared for warnings to change quickly. [10]

C.2.3 Warning

- Met Office app, website, and broadcast media.
- Red warnings are widely broadcast and may be accompanied by Emergency Alerts for local impacts.
- For power cuts: your network operator’s cut map and **105**.

C.2.4 Before

- Sign up for alerts and warnings; learn the hazards in your area.

- Keep torches, batteries, a power bank and warm clothing ready — “people cope better with power cuts when they have prepared for them in advance”. [10]
- Secure loose outdoor items before a storm; park away from trees.
- **Heat:** close curtains on sunny sides, keep windows shut during the day when it is hotter outside, drink regularly, check on older and vulnerable neighbours.
- **Cold:** know where your stopcock is, lag exposed pipes, keep one room warm.
- **Winter car kit:** torch, in-car charger, warm clothes and blankets, high-visibility clothing, jump leads, food and drink, shovel; a first aid kit is also sensible. [6]

C.2.5 During

- **Red warning:** do not travel unless essential; stay indoors.
- Stay away from the coast during storms — large waves can sweep people off their feet and out to sea. Keep dogs on a lead near cliffs. [10]
- Report power cuts on **105** (England, Scotland, Wales) or **03457 643643** (Northern Ireland).
- Before power returns, switch off and unplug irons, ovens, heaters, TVs and computers.
- Keep fridge and freezer doors closed.
- Use torches, not candles.
- In heat: avoid strenuous activity in the hottest part of the day; never leave anyone in a parked car; check on people who live alone.

C.2.6 After

- Check on neighbours, especially anyone older, ill or living alone.
- Photograph damage before repairs, for insurance.
- Check food in the fridge and freezer; discard anything that has warmed up.
- Have a qualified person check electrical equipment affected by a power cut or water.

C.2.7 Where to go

- Stay at home unless told otherwise.
- Libraries, shopping centres and community centres are often designated cool spaces in heatwaves; your council will say which. [VERIFY per council]

C.2.8 Checklist

- [ ] Met Office app installed with warnings enabled
- [ ] Torch, batteries and power bank ready
- [ ] Warm clothing and blankets
- [ ] Winter car kit packed
- [ ] Power cut number known (105 / 03457 643643)
- [ ] Vulnerable neighbours identified

C.3 Wildfire

C.3.1 Risk in the UK

Wildfire is a named risk in the National Risk Register, alongside volcanic eruption, earthquake and severe space weather.[1] The Be Ready campaign cites “the wildfires this summer” as one of the events showing how severe weather disrupts services. [9]

C.3.2 Official plan

Fire and rescue services lead the response, supported by landowners (Forestry England, Forestry and Land Scotland, Natural Resources Wales, National Trust), the police for evacuation and road closures, and local authorities for rest centres. Fire-danger ratings are issued by the Met Office and the fire services. [VERIFY: current fire severity index source]

C.3.3 Warning

- Fire severity index and local fire service advice.
- Emergency Alert or police loudhailer for evacuation.
- Early signs: smell of smoke, haze or ash, an orange glow on the horizon, aircraft and helicopters, road closures.

C.3.4 Before

- Do not light fires, barbecues or campfires in or near dry vegetation; follow any total fire ban.
- Never discard cigarettes or glass in the countryside.
- Keep access tracks clear so fire engines can get through; do not park in gateways.
- Know two ways out of your area.
- Have a grab bag ready.

C.3.5 During

1. **Call 999** and give the exact location.
2. Leave early — do not wait to be told if you can see fire approaching.
3. Move **away** from the fire and across its path, not in front of it.
4. Close windows and air vents in the car; do not stop in smoke.
5. If trapped, go to a large open area with little vegetation, or into a building, and call 999.
6. Follow the emergency services’ instructions exactly.

C.3.6 After

- Stay off burnt ground: roots can smoulder and trees can fall.
- Do not return until the fire service says it is safe.
- Photograph damage for insurance.

C.3.7 Where to go

- Follow the evacuation route given by police or fire service.
- Rest centres are arranged by the local authority.

C.3.8 Checklist

- [ ]

- [ ] Two escape routes from my area known
- [ ] Grab bag ready
- [ ] Local fire service advice checked in dry weather
- [ ] Nothing burnable left outside in dry spells

C.4 Power cut and prolonged blackout

C.4.1 Risk in the UK

Cyber attacks on electricity infrastructure and other failures are named risks in the National Risk Register.[1] Most outages are short, but a national energy shortage could trigger **rota disconnection** — planned, rotating cuts.

C.4.2 Official plan

- **Distribution network operators** run the local grid and restore supply; the **National Energy System Operator (NESO)** balances the national system.
- In a national shortfall, **rota disconnection** would cut areas in turn. Great Britain is divided into **18 load blocks** of about 5% of demand each, disconnected in **3-hour periods** (eight per 24 hours). The **Secretary of State** decides the level and period; **NESO** issues activation schedules to network operators **by 17:30 the day before**, and implementation should take no more than **48 hours**. **Protected sites** — hospitals with A&E or ICU, water and sewerage, airports, prisons and critical data centres — are never disconnected. [42]
- In **Northern Ireland**, planned emergency power cuts switch off **at least 5% of households at once**, for about **3 hours** once or twice a day; **SONI** instructs **NIE Networks**, and each meter has a block letter.[43]
- The **Demand Flexibility Service** pays households to shift electricity use at peak times. It ran from winter 2022/23 and became a year-round tool on **27 November 2024**. You join through a registered supplier or aggregator and need a smart meter; there is no penalty for not responding. [44]
- **Priority Services Register (PSR)** customers — people with a health condition or reduced mobility, pensionable age, medical dependence on supply, children under 5, communication needs, a mental health or cognitive condition, or a temporary need after hospital or bereavement — get advance warning and extra support. In Northern Ireland these are **Customer Care Registers**. [12]
- Telecare and landline providers may supply a battery backup unit for a minimum of **one hour**. [11]

C.4.3 Warning

- Report and check outages on **105** (England, Scotland, Wales) or **03457 643643** (Northern Ireland); operator websites show live maps.
- PSR customers get advance notice.
- Early signs of rota disconnection: public warnings of a capacity shortfall, appeals to cut demand, advance notice to PSR customers.

C.4.4 Before

- Find your **load block letter** at powercut105.com and write it down.
- Torch, batteries, power bank, battery or wind-up radio.
- Cash — card machines and ATMs fail.
- Keep a charged mobile; emergency calls roam onto any available network.
- Fill a thermos with hot water; keep blankets together.
- Know how to open garage doors and gates without power.
- Register for the PSR if eligible.

C.4.5 During

1. Switch off and unplug irons, ovens, heaters, TVs and computers so they do not surge when power returns.
2. Keep fridge and freezer closed.
3. Use torches, not candles.
4. Keep one room warm and live in it.
5. Check on neighbours.
6. Call **105**, not 999, unless there is a genuine emergency.
7. If you depend on medical equipment, contact your supplier and your care provider.

C.4.6 After

- Check food that has warmed up and throw it away.
- Check smoke alarms, heating and medical equipment before relying on them.
- Reset clocks and timers.
- Report damage to your network operator.

C.4.7 Where to go

- Stay at home unless told otherwise.
- Community hubs and council buildings may have power and information.
- PSR customers can ask their operator for extra support.

C.4.8 Checklist

- [ ] Load block letter known
- [ ] 105 / 03457 643643 written down
- [ ] Torches, batteries, power bank, radio
- [ ] Cash at home
- [ ] PSR registration checked
- [ ] Medical equipment plan agreed with supplier

C.5 Telecommunications failure

C.5.1 Risk in the UK

Cyber attacks on **telecommunications systems** and on digital infrastructure are named risks, as is **total loss of transatlantic telecommunications cables**. [1] Emergency Alerts depend on 4G/5G masts, so a telecoms failure also removes a warning channel.

C.5.2 Official plan

Ofcom regulates telecoms; operators must maintain resilience. Government guidance tells households to keep a battery or wind-up radio precisely because alerts and internet may fail together. [6]

C.5.3 Warning

- Loss of mobile signal, broadband, or both; failures of card payments and apps.
- A **landline** may still work if only mobile is down, and vice versa.

C.5.4 Before

- Write down important phone numbers on paper.
- Keep a battery or wind-up radio.
- Keep cash.
- Know your provider’s fault number.
- Agree a physical meeting point with family, since calls may fail.

C.5.5 During

- Use text messages — they often get through when calls fail.
- Try a landline, or a neighbour’s connection.
- Listen to the radio for information.
- Go to a community hub or library for internet access.
- Do not assume an online rumour is true; check the radio.

C.5.6 After

- Check bank and card statements for fraud after an outage.
- Change passwords if you suspect compromise.
- Report faults to your provider and keep a record for compensation claims.

C.5.7 Where to go

- Libraries, community hubs and council buildings for internet and information.

C.5.8 Checklist

- [ ] Paper list of phone numbers
- [ ] Battery or wind-up radio
- [ ] Cash
- [ ] Meeting point agreed
- [ ] Provider fault number written down

C.6 Drinking water loss and sewer flooding

C.6.1 Risk in the UK

Water infrastructure failure or loss of drinking water, and **reservoir/dam collapse**, are named risks in the National Risk Register 2026.[1] Sewer flooding commonly follows heavy rain.

C.6.2 Official plan

Water companies must maintain supply and hold emergency plans; they distribute bottled water when supply fails. Local authorities lead on rest centres and public health advice during an outage. [VERIFY: statutory duty and timescales]

C.6.3 Warning

- **“Do not drink”** or boil-water notices, or loss of pressure.
- Tankers and bottled-water points announced by the water company and council.
- Sewer flooding: water backing up in toilets and drains during heavy rain.

C.6.4 Before

- Store **3 litres per person per day for 3 days** for drinking, and more for cooking and washing. [6]
- Keep bottled water, or clean containers you can fill.
- Know where your **stopcock** is.
- Check your home’s risk of surface water and sewer flooding.

C.6.5 During

- Follow boil or do-not-drink notices exactly; boiling does not remove every contaminant.
- Use bottled water for drinking, brushing teeth, preparing food and for babies.
- Do not drink from private wells or streams.
- For sewer flooding: keep children and pets away; wear gloves and boots; wash hands; do not use electrical equipment that has been wet.

C.6.6 After

- Flush and clean pipes as your water company advises.
- Have flooded electrics checked.
- Report sewer flooding to your water company and council.

C.6.7 Where to go

- Bottled-water distribution points announced by your water company.
- Community hubs and rest centres.

C.6.8 Checklist

- [ ] 3 days of water stored (3 litres/person/day)
- [ ] Stopcock location known
- [ ] Water company emergency number saved
- [ ] Containers for collecting water

C.7 Food and fuel supply disruption

C.7.1 Risk in the UK

Disruption to **global oil trade routes** and **disruption of Russian gas supplies to Europe** are named risks, as is **insolvency affecting fuel supply**. [1]

C.7.2 Official plan

The **Department for Energy Security and Net Zero (DESNZ)** leads on fuel; the **National Energy System Operator** balances gas and electricity. **Food supply** is led by Defra with the food industry. Emergency powers under the Civil Contingencies Act allow rationing and requisition, within the limits in B.2.

C.7.3 Warning

- Empty shelves, purchase limits, forecourt closures.
- Public appeals to reduce demand.
- Rationing would be announced officially.

C.7.4 Before

- Keep **3 days of non-perishable food** that needs no cooking or refrigeration: tinned meat, fish or vegetables, dried fruit and nuts. Buy food you would normally eat. [6]
- Keep a manual tin opener.
- Do not hoard — hoarding creates the shortage.

C.7.5 During

- Ration what you have; plan meals.
- Do not panic-buy.
- Share with neighbours who cannot get out.
- Follow any official rationing or priority scheme.

C.7.6 After

- Restock; check expiry dates.
- Check food that may have spoiled during a power cut.

C.7.7 Where to go

- Community hubs and food banks may operate.
- Your council will announce any emergency food distribution.

C.7.8 Checklist

- [ ] 3 days of non-perishable food
- [ ] Tin opener
- [ ] Neighbours who may need food identified
- [ ] No hoarding

C.8 Pandemic and infectious disease

C.8.1 Risk in the UK

Pandemic is a named risk in the National Risk Register, with an outbreak of an emerging infectious disease and major animal disease outbreaks such as foot and mouth. [1]

COVID-19 killed **73,766** people in England and Wales in 2020 (12.1% of all deaths) and **67,350** in 2021 (11.5%), counting deaths registered as *due to* COVID-19. The ONS put the UK-wide total at **more than 150,000** by March 2023. [13] [14] [15]

C.8.2 Official plan

- **England:** the **UK Health Security Agency (UKHSA)**, an executive agency of DHSC, covers infectious disease, chemicals, radiation and climate and air-quality hazards. Health protection is largely devolved.[16]
- **Scotland: Public Health Scotland**, an NHS Board, operating since 1 April 2020. [17]
- **Wales: Public Health Wales**, one of the 11 organisations making up NHS Wales and a Category 1 responder under the Civil Contingencies Act. [18]
- **Northern Ireland:** the **Public Health Agency (PHA)**. [19]
- **Vaccination policy** is advised by the **JCVI**, an expert committee meeting three times a year. [20]
- A **Pandemic Preparedness Strategy** was published on **25 March 2026**, replacing the 2011 influenza strategy; findings from Exercise Pegasus are due in winter 2026. [21]

Stockpiles. The UK holds **UK-wide CBRN stockpiles** and **UK-wide pandemic stockpiles** of antibiotics, antivirals, vaccines, fluids and needles/syringes, plus **England-only pandemic PPE**. Hospital medicines suppliers must hold at least **8 weeks'** stock and NHS Supply Chain around **4 weeks**. Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland hold their own PPE stocks. [22]

Inquiry. The UK COVID-19 Inquiry has finished public hearings; the sixth report (Care Sector) was published **20 October 2026**, the seventh (Test, Trace, Isolate) is due **19 November 2026**, and "a further four reports will follow".[23]

C.8.3 Warning

- UKHSA and devolved public health announcements; NHS messages.
- Early signs: rising case numbers, school or workplace outbreaks, changes in testing or vaccination advice.

C.8.4 Before

- Keep vaccinations up to date; check your records.
- Keep 3 days of supplies in case you cannot go out.
- Keep paracetamol, a thermometer, soap and hand sanitiser.
- Keep a written list of your medication and doses.
- Request repeat prescriptions up to **5 working days** before you need them. [6]
- Have ready-to-feed baby formula if relevant — you may not be able to boil water safely. [6]

C.8.5 During

- Follow official guidance on distancing, isolation, masks and travel.
- Wash hands often with soap and water; cover coughs and sneezes.
- Ventilate rooms.
- Stay home if you are ill and avoid contact with people at high risk.
- Do not visit hospitals or care homes if you have symptoms.
- Look after your mental health (see F.8).

C.8.6 After

- Catch up on missed vaccinations and routine care.
- Watch for long-term symptoms and seek help.
- Expect the inquiry's remaining reports to change policy.

C.8.7 Where to go

- **111** for advice; **999** for emergencies.
- Vaccination and testing sites announced by the NHS and your council.
- Community pharmacies for advice and medicines.

C.8.8 Checklist

- [ ] Vaccinations up to date
- [ ] 3 days of supplies
- [ ] Medicines list written down
- [ ] Repeat prescription timing known (5 working days)
- [ ] Soap, sanitiser, thermometer, paracetamol

C.9 Chemical incidents and industrial accidents

C.9.1 Risk in the UK

COMAH (Control of Major Accident Hazards) sites are regulated under the COMAH Regulations 2015, which implement the Seveso III directive. Sites are **upper tier** or **lower tier**. The competent authority is the **Health and Safety Executive (HSE)** together with the Environment Agency in England, Natural Resources Wales in Wales, SEPA in Scotland, and HSENI with the NI Environment Agency in Northern Ireland.[24]

The public register of COMAH sites is searchable by area — check your neighbourhood now. [25]

Northern Ireland publishes a list of **28 establishments** (11 upper tier, 17 lower tier). [26]

Historic example: **Buncefield** oil depot, Hemel Hempstead, **11 December 2005** — explosions and a fire that burned for several days, over 40 injured, no fatalities, large-scale evacuation, and almost **£10 million** in fines and costs. [27]

Major Accident Hazard pipelines are regulated by HSE under the Pipelines Safety Regulations 1996. [28]

C.9.2 Official plan

- Upper-tier operators must produce a safety report and an **off-site emergency plan** with the local authority.
- **CHEMET** — the Met Office's chemical meteorology service — gives fire and police services plume and dispersion forecasts, normally emailed within **20 minutes**. [29]
- The fire and rescue service leads, supported by the Environment Agency and public health bodies.

C.9.3 Warning

- **Emergency Alert** with "go in, stay in, tune in".
- Sirens at some major sites [VERIFY locally].

- Sight or smell: a visible plume, unusual odour, stinging eyes, coughing, dead wildlife.

C.9.4 Before

- Find out whether you live near a COMAH site or a major hazard pipeline; the register is searchable by area.[25]
- Keep tape and plastic sheeting to seal windows, vents and doors if advised.
- Know how to turn off ventilation and air conditioning.

C.9.5 During

Official UK advice for a chemical release is **“go in, stay in, tune in”**:

1. **Get into a building** — any building other than the one involved. Vehicles and tents give inadequate protection.
2. **Close external doors and windows.**
3. **Shut off fans and air conditioning**; close air vents, including trickle vents.
4. **Do not collect children from school** — they will be sheltered there.
5. **Do not evacuate unless told to.**
6. **Tune in** to local radio or TV.
7. If exposed: **remove, remove, remove** — leave the area, remove outer clothing (this removes about **90%** of contamination), dry-absorb then rinse. [30]

C.9.6 After

- Do not eat produce from an affected garden until told it is safe.
- Follow decontamination advice; bag contaminated clothing.
- Seek medical help for breathing difficulty, eye irritation or skin burns.

C.9.7 Where to go

- **Stay inside** — that is the default. Evacuate only on official instruction.
- If evacuated, you may be checked and decontaminated before going to a rest centre. [30]

C.9.8 Checklist

- [ ] COMAH register checked for my area
- [ ] Ventilation shut-off known
- [ ] Tape and plastic sheeting
- [ ] Battery radio
- [ ] Know not to collect children from school

C.10 Radiation emergency

C.10.1 Risk in the UK

The **Office for Nuclear Regulation (ONR)** regulates nuclear safety and security. Great Britain has had **no nuclear accident with off-site consequences since Windscale in 1957**. [31]

Regulated sites include Sellafield, Dounreay, Hinkley Point A/B/C, Sizewell A/B/C, Hartlepool, Heysham 1 and 2, Torness, Dungeness A/B, Hunterston A/B, Wylfa, Oldbury, Berkeley, Bradwell, Trawsfynydd, Chapelcross, Springfields, Capenhurst, the Low Level Waste Repository, Harwell, Winfrith, Amersham, Lillyhall, Rosyth, Barrow, Rolls-Royce sites, AWE Aldermaston and Burghfield, and Devonport Royal Dockyard, plus MOD sites including Vulcan, Loch Ewe, Loch Goil, Clyde Naval Base and Portsmouth. [32]

REPPIR 2019 requires operators to assess hazards and requires the local authority to define a **Detailed Emergency Planning Zone** and an **Outline Planning Zone**, prepare an off-site emergency plan, and give prior information to the public. [33]

C.10.2 Official plan

- The local authority prepares the off-site plan for each site; the operator plans on-site.
- **Stable iodine** is distributed where there could be a risk of radioactive iodine release; all nuclear reactor sites with that risk have specific distribution plans. [34]
- Public advice is **go in, stay in, tune in**; you may need to stay indoors for **1 to 2 days**.

C.10.3 Warning

- Emergency Alert, radio, TV.
- Sirens at some sites [VERIFY].
- No reliable sensory warning — radiation cannot be seen, smelled or tasted. Rely only on official messages.

C.10.4 Before

- Find out whether you live inside a Detailed Emergency Planning Zone — your council publishes this.
- Check whether you are eligible for stable iodine tablets and where they are kept.
- Know how to turn off ventilation and close windows.
- Keep a battery radio.

C.10.5 During

1. **Go in, stay in, tune in.** Shelter indoors.
2. Close windows and doors; turn off ventilation, fans and air conditioning.
3. **Take stable iodine only if officially told to.** It is most effective from **24 hours before** to **2 hours after** exposure, is still useful up to **8 hours** after, and **must not be first taken more than 24 hours after** exposure. [34]
4. Do not go outside to collect children — schools shelter pupils.
5. Do not eat or drink anything from your garden or local sources until told it is safe.

Why sheltering works: sheltering in a typical house cuts inhaled exposure by about **40%** and direct exposure by about **85%**.[34]

C.10.6 After

- Leave shelter only when officially told.
- Follow advice about food, water and produce.
- Return iodine tablets or follow instructions on disposal.
- Register for health monitoring if offered.

C.10.7 Where to go

- **Stay indoors.** Evacuate only if instructed.
- Rest centres if evacuated; expect monitoring and decontamination first.

C.10.8 Checklist

- [ ] Checked whether I live in a REPPIR emergency planning zone
- [ ] Stable iodine eligibility and location known
- [ ] Ventilation shut-off known
- [ ] Battery radio
- [ ] Know: go in, stay in, tune in

C.11 Cyber attack on critical infrastructure

C.11.1 Risk in the UK

The National Risk Register lists cyber attacks on **gas**, **electricity**, **civil nuclear**, **fuel supply**, **health and social care**, **transport**, **telecommunications** and **UK retail banking** infrastructure, plus cyber attacks on infrastructure generally and **total loss of transatlantic telecommunications cables**.[1]

C.11.2 Official plan

- The **National Cyber Security Centre (NCSC)**, part of GCHQ, is the technical authority; it issues advisories and supports victims.
- **Ofcom** and sector regulators oversee resilience; the **NIS Regulations** impose security and incident-reporting duties on essential services.
- The Civil Contingencies Act framework applies if an attack causes an “emergency” as defined in B.2.

C.11.3 Warning

- Services failing simultaneously across sectors; ransomware demands; official advisories.
- Emergency Alert if there is an immediate danger to life.

C.11.4 Before

- Install updates; use a password manager; turn on two-factor authentication.
- Keep **offline backups**.
- Keep cash.
- Keep paper copies of important numbers and documents.
- Know how to report fraud.

C.11.5 During

- Do not pay ransoms.
- Disconnect affected devices from the network.
- Follow NCSC and provider advice; check a second channel before believing a message.
- Do not click links in unexpected messages.
- Use cash if card payments fail.

C.11.6 After

- Change passwords from a clean device.

- Check bank statements.
- Report to **Action Fraud** and the NCSC.
- Restore from backup.

C.11.7 Where to go

- Community hubs and libraries for internet access.
- Bank branches for cash and advice.

C.11.8 Checklist

- [ ] Updates and 2FA on
- [ ] Offline backup
- [ ] Cash at home
- [ ] Paper copies of key information

C.12 Terrorism and public order incidents

C.12.1 Risk in the UK

Terrorism is a named risk, covering international terrorist attacks, Northern Ireland-related terrorism, attacks with explosive devices and marauding attacks in public places, attacks on transport, CBRN attacks, conventional attacks on infrastructure and cyber attacks on infrastructure. [1]

C.12.2 Official plan

- **MI5** and **Counter Terrorism Policing** lead intelligence and investigations; the **Joint Terrorism Analysis Centre (JTAC)** sets the national threat level.
- **Current threat level: SEVERE** — “an attack is highly likely” — raised from SUBSTANTIAL on **30 April 2026**. Northern Ireland-related terrorism in Northern Ireland is **SUBSTANTIAL**. [50]
- Police lead the response; fire and ambulance support; local authorities open rest centres and family assistance centres.
- The **Terrorism Act 2000** and the **Counter-Terrorism and Border Security Act 2019** provide powers.

C.12.3 Warning

- Threat level announcements; police appeals.
- Emergency Alert if there is an ongoing danger to life.
- No warning before an attack — that is the nature of it.

C.12.4 Before

- Know the exits wherever you go.
- Report suspicious behaviour to the police (999 if urgent, otherwise 101, or the anti-terrorist hotline).
- Learn **Run, Hide, Tell**.

C.12.5 During

Run, Hide, Tell (official UK advice): 1. **Run** to a place of safety if you can. Leave your belongings. 2. **Hide** if you cannot run: lock or barricade yourself in, silence your phone, stay quiet and out of sight. 3. **Tell** the police by calling 999 once it is safe. 4. Follow police instructions; keep your hands visible.

If a crowd crushes: keep your arms in front of your chest, move with the flow, stay on your feet, and do not bend down to pick things up.

C.12.6 After

- Expect the area to be cordoned off for a long time.
- Use official sources; do not spread images of victims.
- Seek support: the police set up a casualty bureau and family liaison; Samaritans is on **116 123**.
- Terrorism insurance for commercial property runs through **Pool Re** (see G.4).

C.12.7 Where to go

- Follow evacuation directions; move away from the incident.
- Rest centres and family assistance centres announced by police and council.

C.12.8 Checklist

- [ ] Exits known in places I visit
- [ ] Run, Hide, Tell understood
- [ ] Phone charged
- [ ] Meeting point agreed with household

C.13 Armed conflict and national emergency

C.13.1 Risk in the UK

Armed conflict is covered by the Civil Contingencies Act definition of an emergency — war or terrorism threatening serious damage to the security of the UK — and by Part 2 emergency powers. [35]

C.13.2 Official plan

- **COBR** coordinates; the **Armed Forces** defend the UK and NATO territory.
- **MACA** — Military Aid to the Civil Authorities — provides military support to civil responders.
- Emergency regulations under Part 2 can be made, subject to the strict limits in B.2: they **cannot** compel military service, **cannot** ban strikes, **cannot** create serious offences, and **cannot** amend the Human Rights Act.
- **There is currently no conscription** in the UK. [VERIFY current legislative position]
- In a nuclear attack the UK maintains **Standing Defence Nuclear Command** so lawful authority survives; each Prime Minister writes letters of last resort to submarine commanders. [VERIFY]

C.13.3 Warning

- Emergency Alert with instructions; sirens; broadcast alerts.

- In a nuclear attack there is **no general public attack warning today** — the **four-minute warning** system was decommissioned in 1992. [VERIFY]

C.13.4 Before

- Keep at least **3 days** of supplies; consider **7 days** if you can.
- Have a battery radio and spare batteries.
- Keep paper copies of documents.
- Identify your shelter — an internal room, basement or underground car park, away from windows.
- Agree a household plan and meeting points.

C.13.5 During

1. **Go in, stay in, tune in.**
2. Shelter in an internal room, basement or underground space, away from windows.
3. If outside, lie flat and protect your head; do not look at a flash.
4. Turn off gas, electricity and water if safe.
5. Listen to the radio.
6. Stay sheltered until officially told it is safe — fallout decays over days.

C.13.6 After

- Do not go outside until told; radioactive fallout loses intensity over time.
- Follow instructions on food, water and evacuation.
- Register with the authorities for help and to inform relatives.

C.13.7 Where to go

- Shelter in place; evacuate only on official instruction.

C.13.8 Checklist

- [ ] 3–7 days of supplies
- [ ] Battery radio
- [ ] Paper documents
- [ ] Sheltering place identified
- [ ] Household plan agreed

C.14 Transport accidents (rail, air, sea, tunnel)

C.14.1 Risk in the UK

The National Risk Register lists **rail accidents**, **large passenger vessel accidents** and other transport risks, plus terrorist attacks on transport. [1]

C.14.2 Official plan

- The **Rail Accident Investigation Branch (RAIB)** investigates rail accidents; the **Air Accidents Investigation Branch (AAIB)** and the **Marine Accident Investigation Branch (MAIB)** cover air and sea.
- The emergency services lead, with the transport operator and local authority.

C.14.3 Warning

- No warning. An Emergency Alert only if the surrounding area is at risk.

C.14.4 Before

- Know the exits in trains, aircraft and ferries.
- Listen to the safety briefing; count rows to the nearest exit.
- Keep your seatbelt on in aircraft during take-off, landing and turbulence.

C.14.5 During

Train: pull the emergency alarm; follow crew instructions; leave by the designated door; avoid touching the electrified third rail or overhead lines. **Aircraft:** adopt the brace position; leave belongings behind; stay low if there is smoke; count rows to the exit. **Ferry or ship:** go to the muster station; put on a lifejacket; follow crew instructions. **Tunnel:** use the nearest emergency exit; stay low under smoke.

C.14.6 After

- Move well away from the wreckage and any fire.
- Report to the emergency services so you can be accounted for.
- Seek medical attention even if you feel fine — shock, smoke inhalation and internal injury can be delayed.
- Expect investigation cordons to remain for a long time.

C.14.7 Where to go

- Follow evacuation directions; assemble where told.
- A reception centre will be set up for uninjured survivors and relatives.

C.14.8 Checklist

- [ ] Exits noted on every journey
- [ ] Safety briefing listened to
- [ ] Phone charged
- [ ] Someone knows my travel plans

C.15 Mass evacuation and displacement

C.15.1 Risk in the UK

Mass evacuation can follow flooding, wildfire, a chemical or radiation release, or a terrorist attack. The NRR's coastal flooding scenario assumes "a large number of people would require evacuation and shelter, with a significant proportion of these requiring assistance". [2]

C.15.2 Official plan

- **Evacuation and Shelter Guidance** (Cabinet Office, 2014) is the planning framework: risk-based planning, evacuation, shelter, short-term shelter and **rest centre** management. [36]
- Local authorities open **rest centres** and arrange emergency accommodation; the police lead evacuation; the voluntary sector staffs rest centres.

C.15.3 Warning

- Emergency Alert, police loudhailer, door-to-door knocking, BBC local radio.
- Flood warnings for flood-related evacuation (see C.1.3).

C.15.4 Before

- Keep a grab bag (see F.6) with documents, medication, cash and a charger.
- Agree a meeting point and an out-of-area contact.
- Know your nearest rest centre and two routes there.
- Arrange transport if you have mobility needs; register with the PSR.
- Plan for pets — many rest centres cannot accept animals.

C.15.5 During

1. Leave when told; do not delay.
2. Turn off gas, electricity and water if safe.
3. Take your grab bag, medication, documents, phone and charger.
4. Lock up and leave a note saying where you have gone.
5. Follow the designated route.
6. Register at the rest centre — this is how relatives find you.
7. Help neighbours who need assistance.

C.15.6 After

- Do not return until the area is declared safe.
- Register with the council for help with housing, insurance and support.
- Tell relatives you are safe; use official missing-person channels rather than social media rumours.
- Seek mental health support if needed (see F.8).

C.15.7 Where to go

- Rest centres announced by your council and the police.
- Community hubs for food, clothing, shelter and advice.
- Family or friends outside the affected area.

C.15.8 Checklist

- [ ] Grab bag ready
- [ ] Meeting point and out-of-area contact agreed
- [ ] Nearest rest centre known
- [ ] Pet arrangements made
- [ ]

- [ ] Documents and medication ready

C.16 Reservoir and dam failure

C.16.1 Risk in the UK

Reservoir/dam collapse is a named risk in the National Risk Register. [1] Large reservoirs above towns are regulated under the Reservoirs Act 1975, with statutory inspection by qualified civil engineers. [VERIFY: current Act and regulator]

C.16.2 Official plan

- Reservoir owners must maintain and inspect their structures and prepare on-site plans.
- Local authorities include reservoir failure in their off-site planning; the Environment Agency is the enforcement authority in England. [VERIFY]

C.16.3 Warning

- Emergency Alert, police loudhailer, door-to-door.
- Early signs: unusual changes in reservoir level, seepage or cracking at the dam, sudden muddy water downstream.

C.16.4 Before

- Check whether you live in a downstream flood-risk area from a reservoir — the Environment Agency's long-term flood risk service includes reservoirs where data is available. [3]
- Know your escape route to higher ground.

C.16.5 During

1. Move to higher ground immediately — do not wait for confirmation.
2. Do not drive or walk through the flood path.
3. Follow emergency services' directions.

C.16.6 After

- Stay away from the dam and the flood path until declared safe.
- Avoid contaminated water and debris.
- Document damage for insurance.

C.16.7 Where to go

- Higher ground, away from the valley floor.
- Rest centres announced by the council.

C.16.8 Checklist

- [ ] Reservoir flood risk checked for my address
- [ ] Route to higher ground known
- [ ] Grab bag ready

C.17 Space weather and electromagnetic events

C.17.1 Risk in the UK

Severe space weather is a named risk in the National Risk Register. [1] A major geomagnetic storm can induce currents in power grids, disrupt satellite navigation and high-frequency radio, and damage satellites. There is no UK-specific plan for a man-made electromagnetic pulse (EMP) published for the public. [VERIFY]

C.17.2 Official plan

- The **Met Office** runs the UK's **Space Weather Operations Centre**, which issues forecasts and alerts to government, industry and infrastructure operators. [VERIFY: current service name]
- Grid operators take mitigating action (reducing transformer load, avoiding certain switching operations).

C.17.3 Warning

- Met Office space weather alerts; aurora visible unusually far south.
- For a man-made EMP there would be no warning — equipment would simply fail.

C.17.4 Before

- Keep a battery radio, torches, cash and paper documents.
- Keep electronic equipment you rely on unplugged when not in use.
- Have a plan for medical equipment that depends on mains power.

C.17.5 During

- Assume power, telecoms and satellite navigation may fail.
- Listen to the radio.
- Turn off and unplug sensitive equipment to reduce surge risk.

C.17.6 After

- Have electrical equipment checked before reuse.
- Expect GPS-based services (navigation, some payment systems, timing) to be unreliable for a period.

C.17.7 Where to go

- Stay at home unless told otherwise.

C.17.8 Checklist

- [ ] Battery radio and torches
- [ ] Cash
- [ ] Medical equipment plan
- [ ] Paper maps

C.18 Drought, heat and water shortage

C.18.1 Risk in the UK

Drought and **high temperatures and heatwaves** are separate named risks in the National Risk Register.[1]

C.18.2 Official plan

- The **Environment Agency** (England) and **Natural Resources Wales** manage water resources and can impose **hosepipe bans** and, in severe drought, drought orders and emergency drought orders.
- Water companies publish drought plans; the government convenes the National Drought Group.
- UKHSA issues heat-health alerts with the Met Office. [VERIFY: current alert naming]

C.18.3 Warning

- Hosepipe bans and drought permits/orders announced by water companies and regulators.
- Heat-health alerts and Met Office warnings.

C.18.4 Before

- Store water (3 litres/person/day for 3 days).
- Fix leaks and fit water-saving devices.
- Know your water company's restrictions and priority codes.

C.18.5 During

- Follow hosepipe bans and restrictions.
- In heat: hydrate, avoid the hottest hours, keep rooms cool, check on vulnerable people.
- Never leave children or animals in parked cars.

C.18.6 After

- Check for heat damage to pipes and foundations after a drought.
- Continue water-saving measures as advised.

C.18.7 Where to go

- Cool public spaces announced by your council during heatwaves.

C.18.8 Checklist

- [ ] Water stored
- [ ] Heat plan for vulnerable household members
- [ ] Water company restrictions known

C.19 Animal disease outbreak

C.19.1 Risk in the UK

Major outbreaks of foot and mouth disease and other animal diseases are named risks in the National Risk Register 2026.[1]

C.19.2 Official plan

- **Defra** leads in England, with the **Animal and Plant Health Agency (APHA)**; the devolved administrations lead in Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland.
- Controls include movement restrictions, culling, protection zones and vaccination in some cases.

C.19.3 Warning

- Official announcements of disease control zones.
- Signage on roads and at farm entrances.

C.19.4 Before

- Livestock keepers: keep movement records and biosecurity measures up to date.
- The public: avoid contact with livestock and do not walk through farmland where restrictions apply.

C.19.5 During

- Obey movement restrictions and footpath closures.
- Do not move animals or animal products without a licence.
- Report suspected disease immediately.

C.19.6 After

- Restrictions may outlast the outbreak by months; follow official notices.
- Livestock keepers may claim compensation under the scheme in force. [VERIFY]

C.19.7 Where to go

- n/a — the controls are movement and contact restrictions, not evacuation.

C.19.8 Checklist

- [ ] Aware of local restrictions
- [ ] Contact with livestock avoided where restricted
- [ ] Suspected disease reporting route known

1. https://www.nhs.uk/nhs-services/urgent-and-emergency-care-services/when-to-call-999/ — call 999 only for a life-threatening emergency; calling 999 does not guarantee an ambulance and you may be advised to make your own way. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
2. https://beready.campaign.gov.uk/be-informed-about-hazards/ — pay attention to official sources; check local radio, local TV and reliable online sources; beware misleading information online. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑

Notes

1. National Risk Register 2026, PDF — natural and environmental hazards (coastal, fluvial and surface water flooding, wildfire, severe space weather, storms, heat, low temperatures, drought, poor air quality), accidents and systems failures (including reservoir/dam collapse and loss of drinking water), and human/animal/plant health. https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/6a50d66b1228eb26a4cab76c/National_Risk_Register_2026.pdf. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
2. National Risk Register 2026, PDF — coastal flooding summary: reasonable worst-case flooding across the east coast of England, large-scale evacuation and shelter, fatalities, and flooded road and rail. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
3. https://www.gov.uk/guidance/flood-alerts-and-warnings-what-they-are-and-what-to-do — the three Environment Agency warning types, what each means, what to do, and the 2–12 hour and 30 minutes–2 hour lead times. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
4. https://www.gov.uk/sign-up-for-flood-warnings — free flood warnings by text, phone or email for England; surface water flooding is not covered; Floodline 0345 988 1188, textphone 0345 602 6340, 24-hour. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
5. https://www.gov.uk/prepare-for-flooding — make a flood plan, and find local support: flood action groups, community flood wardens and community hubs offering food, clothing, shelter and advice. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
6. https://beready.campaign.gov.uk/be-ready-for-emergencies/ — the Be Ready household checklist: 3 days of supplies, 3 litres of water per person per day, non-perishable food, torch, battery radio with written-down frequencies, power bank, cash, document copies, contact and medication lists, first aid kit, medication (request repeats 5 working days ahead), baby and pet supplies; know how to turn off gas, electricity and water; winter car kit. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
7. https://beready.campaign.gov.uk/be-informed-about-hazards/ — do not delay evacuating when asked; delaying or refusing may put your life and responders' lives at risk. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
8. https://www.gov.uk/help-during-flood — contact your local council for help getting emergency accommodation if your home is flood-damaged and uninhabitable. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
9. https://beready.campaign.gov.uk/ and https://www.gov.uk/government/news/households-encouraged-to-take-small-simple-steps-to-stay-prepared-in-an-emergency — the campaign cites storms last winter and this summer's wildfires as the disruption it responds to; three-year campaign, aligned with France, Ireland and the Netherlands on three days of readiness. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
10. https://www.metoffice.gov.uk/weather/warnings-and-advice/uk-warnings — meaning of yellow, amber and red warnings; likelihood and impact framing; advice to prepare for power cuts and for warnings to change quickly; coastal wave safety. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
11. https://beready.campaign.gov.uk/be-informed-about-hazards/power-cuts/ — report power cuts on 105 (England, Scotland, Wales) or 03457 643643 (Northern Ireland); know your load block letter; rota disconnections of about 3 hours; switch off and unplug appliances before restoration; keep fridge and freezer shut; telecare/landline battery backup of at least one hour. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
12. https://www.thepsr.co.uk/ — Priority Services Register eligibility, including children under five; Northern Ireland equivalent is the Customer Care Registers. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
13. ONS, deaths registered due to COVID-19, 2020 — 73,766 deaths, 12.1% of all deaths in England and Wales. https://www.ons.gov.uk/peoplepopulationandcommunity/birthsdeathsandmarriages/deaths/articles/deathsregisteredduetocovid19/2020. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
14. ONS, deaths registered due to COVID-19, 2021 — 67,350 deaths, 11.5% of all deaths in England and Wales. https://www.ons.gov.uk/peoplepopulationandcommunity/birthsdeathsandmarriages/deaths/articles/deathsregisteredduetocovid19/2021. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
15. ONS, Coronavirus (COVID-19) latest insights — UK-wide total of more than 150,000 deaths as at March 2023. https://www.ons.gov.uk/peoplepopulationandcommunity/healthandsocialcare/conditionsanddiseases/articles/coronaviruscovid19/latestinsights. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
16. https://www.gov.uk/government/organisations/uk-health-security-agency/about — UKHSA is an executive agency of DHSC; its remit covers England because health protection is largely devolved. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑

17. https://publichealthscotland.scot/about-us/who-we-are/our-organisation/who-we-are/ — Public Health Scotland is an NHS Board sponsored by the Scottish Government and COSLA, operating since 1 April 2020. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
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D. LOCATIONS AND INFRASTRUCTURE

D.1 Shelters and safe places

There is no public civil-defence shelter network in the UK. UK doctrine is to **shelter in place** or to evacuate to **rest centres** and temporary accommodation arranged by responders. [1]

Type of place	Good for	How to use it
Internal room, cellar or basement	Explosion, blast, fallout	Go low, away from windows, protect head and chest
Underground car park under your home	Blast and fallout	Away from the entrance, away from glass
Any sturdy building other than the one involved	Chemical release, smoke	Close external doors and windows; shut off fans and air conditioning; close vents including trickle vents
Upper floor of a sturdy building	Flooding	Take water, food, radio, phone, medication
Large open area with little vegetation	Wildfire	Go low, cover skin and airways
Rest centre (council-run)	Evacuation	Register on arrival so relatives can find you

Why not a car or a tent: official advice is explicit that **vehicles and tents give inadequate protection** from a chemical release.[1]

D.2 Rest centres and community hubs

- **Rest centres** are opened by local authorities during evacuation. They provide shelter, warmth, food, information and registration.
- **Community hubs** offer "food, clothing, shelter and advice during a flood". [2]
- After a chemical or radiation incident you may be **checked and decontaminated before going to a rest centre**.[1]
- **Note on pets:** many rest centres cannot accept animals. Plan an alternative now.

D.3 Hospitals and emergency departments

- **England:** NHS England, with integrated care boards; **27 designated Major Trauma Centres** in a tiered system of Major Trauma Centre → Trauma Unit → Local Emergency Hospital across 22 major trauma networks.[3][4]
- **London** has four Major Trauma Centres: King's College Hospital, The Royal London Hospital, St George's Hospital and St Mary's Hospital.[5]
- **Scotland:** 14 territorial NHS Boards plus 7 national bodies, including the Scottish Ambulance Service and Public Health Scotland.[6]
- **Wales:** NHS Wales comprises Local Health Boards, trusts and three special health authorities. [7]
- **Northern Ireland:** six Health and Social Care Trusts, including the Northern Ireland Ambulance Service.[8]
- **Air ambulance:** a charity-funded network represented by Air Ambulances UK; you reach it through **999**.
- **Emergency department pressure (England, September 2026):** record **2.44 million** A&E attendances, **806,707** ambulance incidents, **94.9%** adult acute bed occupancy, **13,647** patients a day medically fit for discharge, and a waiting list of **7.4 million** (August 2026). [9]

Practical consequence: in a major incident, expect long waits. Hospitals triage by clinical need, not by arrival order. Do not go to an emergency department unless you need emergency care.

D.4 GP out-of-hours, pharmacies and repeat prescriptions

- **111** is the front door for urgent non-emergency care: out-of-hours GP, dental, mental health triage and emergency prescriptions. **111 online** works from age 5; call for under-fives. Text relay: **18001 111**.[10]
- **Repeat prescriptions:** request them up to **5 working days** before you need them. [2]
- **Community pharmacies** can advise on minor illness and provide some medicines without an appointment.
- **Stockpiles in the supply chain:** hospital medicines suppliers must hold at least **8 weeks'** stock; NHS Supply Chain holds about **4 weeks**. [11]

D.5 Police, fire and ambulance stations

- **Police:** 43 territorial forces in England and Wales, Police Scotland, the PSNI, plus national agencies. Find your local station through **police.uk**; non-emergency **101**.
- **Fire and rescue:** separate services per nation. [VERIFY counts]
- **Ambulance:** regional NHS ambulance trusts in England; national services in Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland.
- **Write down now:** your nearest police station, fire station, A&E, urgent treatment centre, GP surgery, pharmacy and vet — plus two routes to each.

D.6 Government and crisis centres

Body	Role
COBR (Cabinet Office Briefing Rooms)	Cross-government crisis decision-making
Civil Contingencies Secretariat (Cabinet Office)	Resilience policy, National Risk Register
UK Health Security Agency	Health protection in England
Environment Agency	Flood warnings and defences in England; incident hotline **0800 80 70 60**
Met Office	Weather warnings; CHEMET; space weather
Office for Nuclear Regulation	Nuclear safety and security
Health and Safety Executive	COMAH and pipelines
National Cyber Security Centre	Cyber incidents
Local Resilience Forum	Multi-agency planning for your area
Local authority	Rest centres, emergency accommodation, public health

D.7 Water: reservoirs, treatment works, flood defences

- **Water companies** supply drinking water by region; **Scottish Water** and **NI Water** in the devolved nations.
- **Reservoirs** above towns are regulated and inspected; reservoir failure is a named national risk. [1]
- **Flood defences:** the Environment Agency on main rivers and the coast; lead local flood authorities on surface water and ordinary watercourses; internal drainage boards in low-lying land.
- **Reservoir flood risk** is included in the Environment Agency's long-term flood risk service where data is available.[3]

D.8 Energy

- **National Energy System Operator (NESO)** balances electricity nationally.
- **Distribution network operators** run the local grids; gas is distributed by regional gas networks.
- **Rota disconnection** in a national shortfall: your area is identified by a **load block letter** and each rotation lasts about **3 hours**. [11]

- **Priority Services Register** for advance warning and extra support. [12]
- **Electricity distribution: 14 licensed distribution regions** in Great Britain, run by six groups — UK Power Networks, National Grid Electricity Distribution, Northern Powergrid, SP Energy Networks, SSE Networks and Electricity North West. In Northern Ireland, **NIE Networks** distributes and **SONI** operates the transmission system. [45]
- **Gas distribution: eight networks** run by **four companies** — Cadent, Northern Gas Networks, Wales & West Utilities and SGN. **National Gas** owns and operates the **5,000-mile** National Transmission System and acts as gas system operator. [46]
- **Gas storage is small:** Great Britain has **eight storage facilities** with a maximum capacity of **3.2 billion cubic metres** and **117 million m³/day** deliverability. Storage supplied only **8%** of National Transmission System winter demand in 2024/25. **Rough** holds about **54 billion cubic feet** — roughly half of UK gas storage. [47]
- **Nuclear stations** (all EDF in Great Britain): **Torness 1,190 MW, Heysham 1 1,155 MW, Heysham 2 1,230 MW, Hartlepool 1,185 MW, Sizewell B 1,198 MW** — about **12%** of UK electricity demand. The four AGR stations are now expected to run **until March 2030**. Dungeness B, Hunterston B and Hinkley Point B have ceased generating. [48]
- **Coal has been phased out of electricity generation**: from **October 2024** Great Britain no longer uses coal to generate electricity, down from about **40%** in 2012 to zero with the closure of Ratcliffe-on-Soar.[49]

D.9 Telecommunications

- Four mobile network operators plus virtual operators; **Emergency Alerts** run on **4G and 5G**. [4]
- **105** for power cuts; **111** for NHS; **999/112** for emergencies.
- In a telecoms failure, **emergency calls roam onto any available network**. [11]

D.10 Transport

- **England: National Highways** runs motorways and major A-roads — more than **4,500 miles**, carrying a third of all traffic and two thirds of freight. Contact centre **0300 123 5000**, 24/7; live updates at nationalhighways.co.uk. [12]
- **Scotland: Transport Scotland** manages the trunk road network — **3,507 km**, 6% of the road network but **35% of traffic and 60% of HGVs**. **Traffic Scotland: 0800 028 1414**, 24/7, or traffic.gov.scot.[13]
- **Wales: Traffic Wales** manages motorways and trunk roads — **1,080 km** in north and mid Wales and **436 km trunk plus 178 km motorway** in south Wales. Traffic Wales: **0300 123 1213**. [14]
- **Northern Ireland: DfI Roads** is the sole road authority, responsible for **25,970 km** of road (at 1 April 2025). Out-of-hours emergency: **0300 200 7899**; live updates at trafficwatchni.com.[15]
- **Rail: Network Rail** owns and operates the infrastructure in England, Scotland and Wales — **20,000 miles of track**, 30,000 bridges, tunnels and viaducts, and the 20 largest stations (the other 2,500+ are run by train operators). 24-hour emergency helpline **03457 11 41 41**; British Transport Police **0800 40 50 40** or text **61016**. National Rail Enquiries **03457 48 49 50**. [16]
- **Great British Railways is not yet operational.** The Railways Bill was introduced in the Commons on 5 November 2025 and is now in the Lords; GBR is expected to start around **12 months after** Royal Assent (about 2027), bringing track and train together and replacing Network Rail's role. [17]
- **Accidents** are investigated by the **RAIB** (rail), **AAIB** (air) and **MAIB** (sea).
- **Ports** are commercially owned and handled **428.3 million tonnes** of freight in 2025; London is the largest (13%), then Grimsby and Immingham (11%) and Milford Haven (9%). Dover is the largest roll-on/roll-off port. [18]
- **Airports** handled **298.7 million** terminal passengers in the year to November 2025: Heathrow **84.3 million**, Gatwick 42.8 million, Manchester 31.9 million, Stansted 29.7 million, Luton 17.7 million, Edinburgh 16.9 million.[19]
- **Driving in severe weather (Highway Code 226–237):** use headlights when visibility is seriously reduced (generally below **100 m**); stopping distances at least **double** in the wet and up to **ten times** greater on ice. Do not drive unless the journey is essential. Never place a warning triangle on a motorway; if you cannot get out safely, stay belted with hazard lights on and call **999**.[20]

- **Air and sea:** AAIB and MAIB investigate; air ambulance and HM Coastguard respond.
- **Flooding closes roads and railways** — never assume a route is open; check before travelling.

D.11 High-risk sites

- **COMAH sites:** upper-tier and lower-tier; searchable public register. [25]
- **Major Accident Hazard pipelines** regulated by HSE. [28]
- **Nuclear sites:** see C.10.1 for the full ONR list. [32]
- **Military sites:** not published; keep clear of exercises and convoys.

D.12 Maps

- **Flood risk:** check your long-term flood risk (rivers, sea, surface water, reservoirs, groundwater) and the 5-day forecast.[3]
- **Emergency Alerts history:** GOV.UK/alerts lists current and past alerts. [4]
- **COMAH register:** searchable by area. [25]
- **Community Risk Register:** your Local Resilience Forum's published risk register. [12]
- Keep **paper maps** of your area; mobile navigation fails with the network.

Notes

1. https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/chemical-emergencies-information-for-the-public/what-to-do-in-a-chemical-emergency — go in, stay in, tune in; vehicles and tents give inadequate protection; decontamination before a rest centre; mains water typically holds 2–3 days' treated water. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
2. https://www.gov.uk/prepare-for-flooding — community hubs offer food, clothing, shelter and advice during a flood. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
3. https://www.england.nhs.uk/2018/08/more-than-1600-extra-trauma-victims-alive-today-says-major-new-study/ — 27 designated Major Trauma Centres in England. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
4. https://www.england.nhs.uk/wp-content/uploads/2024/03/PRN231106-major-trauma-network-specification-2023.pdf — tiered model across 22 major trauma networks, supporting emergency preparedness and major-incident surge. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
5. https://www.england.nhs.uk/london/london-clinical-networks/our-networks/violence-reduction/london-major-trauma-psychology-network/ — London's four Major Trauma Centres: King's College, Royal London, St George's and St Mary's. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
6. https://www.nhs.scot/ — 14 territorial NHS Boards plus 7 national bodies, including the Scottish Ambulance Service and Public Health Scotland. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
7. https://www.nhs.wales/about-us/ — NHS Wales comprises Local Health Boards, trusts and three special health authorities. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
8. https://www.nidirect.gov.uk/contacts/health-and-social-care-trusts — six Health and Social Care Trusts in Northern Ireland, including the NI Ambulance Service. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
9. https://www.england.nhs.uk/2026/10/ominous-signs-of-winter-pressure-growing-as-aes-and-ambulances-see-record-september/ — September 2026: 2.44 million A&E attendances, 806,707 ambulance incidents, 94.9% adult acute bed occupancy, 13,647 patients a day medically fit for discharge, 7.4 million waiting list (August 2026). Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
10. https://www.nhs.uk/nhs-services/urgent-and-emergency-care-services/when-to-use-111/ — 111 online from age 5, call for under-fives; dental, mental health and emergency prescriptions; text relay 18001 111. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
11. https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/stockpiles-of-medical-products-held-by-dhsc/stockpiles-of-medical-products-held-by-the-department-of-health-and-social-care — UK-wide CBRN and pandemic stockpiles; England-only pandemic PPE; 8 weeks' supplier stock; NHS Supply Chain around 4 weeks; devolved nations hold their own PPE stocks. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
12. https://nationalhighways.co.uk/about-us/what-we-do/ — National Highways runs England's motorways and major A-roads, more than 4,500 miles, a third of all traffic and two thirds of freight; contact centre 0300 123 5000, 24/7. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑

13. https://www.transport.gov.scot/transport-network/roads/the-trunk-road-network and https://www.traffic.gov.scot/contact-us — Transport Scotland manages 3,507 km of trunk road, 6% of the network but 35% of traffic and 60% of HGVs; Traffic Scotland 0800 028 1414, 24/7. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
14. https://traffic.wales/about-us — Traffic Wales: NMWTRA manages 1,080 km; SWTRA manages 436 km trunk plus 178 km motorway; contact 0300 123 1213. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
15. https://www.infrastructure-ni.gov.uk/contact — DfI Roads is the sole road authority in Northern Ireland, 25,970 km of road at 1 April 2025; out-of-hours emergency 0300 200 7899; live updates at trafficwatchni.com. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
16. https://www.networkrail.co.uk/who-we-are/ and https://www.networkrail.co.uk/contact-us/ — 20,000 miles of track, 30,000 bridges, tunnels and viaducts, 20 managed stations and 2,500+ run by operators; 24-hour helpline 03457 11 41 41; BTP 0800 40 50 40 or text 61016; National Rail Enquiries 03457 48 49 50. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
17. https://www.gov.uk/guidance/great-british-railways — Railways Bill introduced 5 November 2025, now in the Lords; GBR expected around 12 months after Royal Assent; will bring track and train together. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
18. https://www.gov.uk/government/statistics/port-freight-annual-statistics-2025/port-freight-annual-statistics-2025-overview-of-port-freight-statistics-and-useful-information — UK ports handled 428.3 million tonnes in 2025; London 13%, Grimsby and Immingham 11%, Milford Haven 9%; Dover the largest ro-ro port. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
19. CAA airport statistics — 298.7 million terminal passengers in the year to November 2025; Heathrow 84.3 m, Gatwick 42.8 m, Manchester 31.9 m, Stansted 29.7 m, Luton 17.7 m, Edinburgh 16.9 m. https://www.caa.co.uk/. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
20. https://www.gov.uk/guidance/the-highway-code/driving-in-adverse-weather-conditions-226-to-237 — headlights when visibility is seriously reduced (generally below 100 m); stopping distances at least double in the wet and up to ten times greater on ice; never use a warning triangle on a motorway; call 999 if you cannot exit safely. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑

E. NATIONAL RESERVES AND CONTINUITY

E.1 Oil, gas and fuel reserves

- The UK holds **strategic fuel obligations** as an IEA and EU member; stocks are held commercially and by government. [VERIFY current obligation and volume]
- **Gas storage capacity in the UK is small relative to demand**, which makes the country sensitive to supply shocks; disruption to Russian gas supplies was removed as an NRR risk in 2026 because UK reliance fell.[11]
- **Fuel rationing** would require emergency regulations under Part 2 of the Civil Contingencies Act, within the limits set out in B.2.

E.2 Food and water

- The UK does **not** hold a national food stockpile for the public. Official advice is that households keep **3 days** of non-perishable food and water. [6]
- **Water** is held by water companies as treated water in the network and in service reservoirs; mains water typically holds **2 to 3 days'** treated water. [1]
- If supply fails, water companies distribute bottled water and tankers; your council announces the distribution points.

E.3 Medical stockpiles

- **UK-wide CBRN stockpiles** and **UK-wide pandemic stockpiles** (antibiotics, antivirals, vaccines, fluids, needles/syringes), plus **England-only pandemic PPE**. [11]
- **Hospital medicines:** suppliers must hold at least **8 weeks'** stock; NHS Supply Chain holds about **4 weeks**.[11]
- **Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland** hold their own PPE stocks. [11]

- **Stable iodine** is distributed around nuclear sites with a credible radioactive iodine risk. [34]

E.4 Rationing and priority

- **Electricity:** in a national shortfall, **rota disconnection** by load block, roughly 3 hours at a time.[11]
- **Priority Services Register** customers are flagged to suppliers for extra support. [12]
- **Healthcare and emergency services** are prioritised in any allocation scheme. [VERIFY]

E.5 Money and payments

- **Keep cash** — a mix of coins and notes — because card machines and ATMs need power and network. [6]
- Emergency calls roam onto any available network, so a phone may still work for 999 even when your own operator is down. [11]
- Banks must maintain operational resilience; outages are reported to regulators. [VERIFY]

E.6 Continuity of government and essential services

- **COBR** and the **Civil Contingencies Secretariat** coordinate national response; **Lead Government Departments** own each risk.
- **Local Resilience Forums** coordinate local response; **rest centres** and emergency accommodation are the local authority's job.
- **Military Aid to the Civil Authorities (MACA)** provides Defence support when civil capacity is exceeded.
- **Emergency regulations** under Part 2 of the Civil Contingencies Act are time-limited to **30 days** and cannot amend the Human Rights Act. [5]
- **Nuclear command:** Standing Defence Nuclear Command ensures lawful authority survives; letters of last resort are held by submarine commanders. [VERIFY]

F. YOUR PREPAREDNESS

F.1 Official advice: three days

The UK government's advice, relaunched as the **Be Ready** campaign on **22 October 2026**, is to be ready for **three days** of disruption. The three-year campaign is explicitly aligned with France, Ireland and the Netherlands, and more than **500 organisations** had signed up at launch. [1]

Why three days: in the first days of an emergency, services are disrupted, responders are stretched, and help cannot reach everyone at once. Being ready for three days means the emergency services can prioritise those who need them most. [1]

Build it gradually. The official advice is to check what you already have, note what is missing, buy a little at a time during normal shopping, check every six months, and talk to your neighbours. [6]

F.2 Emergency kit (official list)

Category	Items
Water	Bottled water for 3 days — **3 litres per person per day** for drinking; more for cooking and washing
Food	**3 days** of non-perishable food needing no refrigeration or cooking: tinned meat, fish or vegetables, dried fruit, nuts. Buy food you would normally eat. Tin opener
Hygiene	Hand sanitiser, wet wipes, bathroom products
Light and warmth	Torch and spare batteries (safer than candles); blankets, sleeping bags, warm clothing
Communication	Battery or wind-up **FM radio**, with frequencies written down; charged **power bank** for phones and compatible medical devices
Money and documents	Cash (coins and notes) **and** cards; printed copies of passports, birth certificates, insurance details and medical equipment instructions; written contact list, medication list and doses
Medical	First aid kit (plasters, bandages, thermometer, antiseptic, eyewash, sterile dressings, gloves, tape, tweezers); essential medication — request repeats up to **5 working days** ahead
Baby	Ready-to-feed formula (you may not be able to boil water), nappies, wipes
Pets	Pet food and bottled water

[6]

Also useful: a spare bag (“grab bag”) ready to take if you must leave quickly; a winter car kit (torch, in-car charger, warm clothes and blankets, high-visibility clothing, jump leads, food and drink, shovel, first aid kit).[6]

F.3 Water and food quantities

Item	Per person per day	3 days	7 days
Water (drinking only)	3 litres	9 litres	21 litres
Water (drinking, cooking, hygiene)	4–5 litres	12–15 litres	28–35 litres
Food energy	2,000–2,500 kcal	~7,000 kcal	~16,000 kcal

Official guidance gives 3 litres per person per day for drinking, noting that **more is needed for cooking and washing**.[6]

F.4 Medication and medical needs

- Keep a written list of all medicines, doses and allergies.
- Request repeat prescriptions up to **5 working days** before you need them. [6]
- If you rely on powered medical equipment, ask your supplier and care provider for a plan now.
- Register for the **Priority Services Register** — it exists exactly for this. [12]
- Telecare and landline providers may supply a battery backup for a minimum of **one hour** — ask yours.[11]

F.5 Power, light, heat and cooking

Need	Without power	Safety
Light	Torch, head torch, battery lamp	**Torches, not candles**
Phone	Power bank, car charger	Keep one device charged for alerts
Heat	Blankets, sleeping bags, warm clothing; heat one room	Never use a barbecue, camping stove or generator indoors (carbon monoxide)
Cooking	Camping stove or barbecue	**Outdoors only**
Water	Stored water, bottled water	Never drink from streams or wells
Food	Non-perishable food needing no cooking	Discard food that has warmed up

Before power returns: **switch off and unplug** irons, ovens, heaters, TVs and computers; keep fridge and freezer doors closed.[11]

F.6 Communication plan

1. Agree a **meeting point** near home and one outside your area.
2. Agree an **out-of-area contact** — someone who can relay messages.
3. Write phone numbers **on paper** and keep them with your kit.
4. Agree **who checks on whom**, especially anyone living alone.
5. Add emergency contacts and medical information to your phone (“ICE” / “Medical ID”).
6. Swap details with neighbours; consider a street messaging group.
7. Give your **noodle plan** to family, neighbours and the out-of-area contact.
8. Teach children when and how to call 999. [6]

F.7 Documents and money

- Printed copies of passports, birth certificates, insurance policies, medical equipment instructions and your medication list. [6]
- Keep them with your kit, in a waterproof bag.
- Keep cash — coins and notes — as well as cards.
- Keep a written record of insurance policy numbers and emergency contacts.

F.8 Mental health and resilience

- **Samaritans: 116 123** — free, 24/7, any phone. Welsh-language line: **0808 164 0123**. [2]
- **NHS 111**, then select the **mental health option**; 111 online also triages mental health. Call **999** or go to A&E if life is at risk. [3]
- **Childline: 0800 1111** for under-19s — the number will not appear on the phone bill. [3]
- **Cruse Bereavement Support: 0808 808 1677**, with 80+ local branches across England, Wales and Northern Ireland.[4]
- **Northern Ireland: Lifeline 0808 808 8000** — free, 24/7 crisis response. [5]
- Practical steps: keep routines, sleep, eat, move, limit news to set times, and help others — helping is one of the strongest protections for your own mental health. [1]

F.9 Vulnerable people

- **Older people and anyone with a health condition:** check on them in heat, cold, and outages.
- **Children under 5** qualify a household for the Priority Services Register. [12]
- **People with disabilities:** plan evacuation routes that work without lifts; the PSR covers reduced mobility.
- **People dependent on electricity for medical equipment:** agree a plan with your supplier and care provider, and register for the PSR.

- **People who do not speak or read English well, or are not online:** the Be Ready campaign was built with charities representing under-represented groups. [1]
- **People in insecure housing or using food banks** are explicitly considered by the campaign. [1]
- **Pets:** plan now — many rest centres cannot take animals.

F.10 Community and volunteering

- Talk to your neighbours; swap contact details and agree who checks on whom. [6]
- Join or start a street or building messaging group.
- Volunteer: the **British Red Cross** (including its UK resilience work), **St John Ambulance**, **RNLI**, mountain rescue, and local flood action groups and community flood wardens. [5]
- “Play your part” is part of the official GOV.UK/Prepare guidance. [6]

F.11 Preparedness for businesses and organisations

- Businesses are **Category 2 responders** if they operate essential services, and must cooperate with responders.
- Every organisation should have a **business continuity plan** and a **flood plan** if relevant. [5]
- The NRR is written for risk and resilience practitioners, including businesses and voluntary organisations.[6]

Notes

1. https://www.gov.uk/government/news/households-encouraged-to-take-small-simple-steps-to-stay-prepared-in-an-emergency — Be Ready campaign: three days of readiness, aligned with France, Ireland and the Netherlands; three-year campaign; more than 500 organisations signed up; built with charities representing under-represented groups including people in insecure housing and people using food banks. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
2. https://www.samaritans.org/how-we-can-help/contact-samaritan/ — Samaritans 116 123, free, 24/7, any phone; Welsh-language line 0808 164 0123. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
3. https://www.nhs.uk/nhs-services/mental-health-services/where-to-get-urgent-help-for-mental-health/ — call 111 and select the mental health option; 111 online triage; 999 or A&E if life is at risk; Childline 0800 1111 for under-19s. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
4. https://www.cruse.org.uk/get-support/ — Cruse Bereavement Support helpline 0808 808 1677, with more than 80 local branches across England, Wales and Northern Ireland. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
5. https://www.publichealth.hscni.net/living-well/mental-health-and-wellbeing/lifeline — Lifeline 0808 808 8000, free, 24/7 crisis response helpline in Northern Ireland. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
6. https://www.gov.uk/prepare — “Play your part”: see how you can volunteer and support your community during an emergency; also signposting to the Priority Services Register, Ready Scotland and NI Direct. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑

G. LAW, RIGHTS AND INSURANCE

G.1 Emergency legislation

Instrument	What it does
Civil Contingencies Act 2004, Part 1	Duties on Category 1 and 2 responders: risk assessment, planning, business continuity, warning and informing the public, information sharing
Civil Contingencies Act 2004, Part 2	Emergency regulations, subject to the triple lock, proportionality, 30-day lapse and the limits in B.2
Emergency Powers Act 1920	The predecessor regime; repealed and replaced by the 2004 Act
Coronavirus Act 2020	Gave sweeping temporary powers during the pandemic; most powers have expired or been suspended. [VERIFY current status]
Public Order Act 1986 / 2023	Public order offences, protests and processions
Police and Criminal Evidence Act 1984 (PACE)	Police powers of stop, search, arrest and detention
Terrorism Act 2000	Terrorism offences, proscription, stop and search powers
Counter-Terrorism and Border Security Act 2019	Further counter-terrorism powers, including at borders
Reserve Forces Act 1996	Call-out of reservists
Radiation (Emergency Preparedness and Public Information) Regulations 2019	Nuclear emergency planning and public information
COMAH Regulations 2015	Major accident hazard sites
Pipelines Safety Regulations 1996	Major accident hazard pipelines

[1]

G.2 Your obligations

- **Follow the instructions of the emergency services.** In an evacuation, delay puts lives at risk. [7]
- **Do not obstruct** responders; do not go to look at an incident.
- **Follow restrictions** imposed under emergency regulations, which can cover movement, gatherings and the requisition of property.
- **Reservists** can be called out under the Reserve Forces Act 1996 for national danger and warlike operations.
- **There is no conscription** in the UK today. [VERIFY]
- Emergency regulations **cannot** require military service or ban industrial action. [4]

G.3 Your rights

- **Emergency regulations cannot amend the Human Rights Act 1998**, and must be proportionate and limited to what the emergency requires. [4]
- Regulations **lapse after 30 days**, and Parliament scrutinises them. [5]
- Offences created under emergency regulations are limited to summary offences with a maximum of **3 months' imprisonment** or a level 5 fine. [4]
- **You have the right to information about risk.** Category 1 responders must warn and inform the public, and REPPIR requires prior information to the public near nuclear sites. [1][33]
- **Data protection:** your personal data is protected by the UK GDPR and the Data Protection Act 2018; Emergency Alerts do not collect your phone number or location. [4]

G.4 Insurance: what is covered

Flood Re is the key scheme for flood cover. It is a reinsurance scheme, not an insurer:

- It runs until **2039**.

- Every UK home insurer pays a **Levy** raising **£160 million a year**.
- Insurers cede flood risk to Flood Re at a **fixed premium based on your council tax band**.
- There is a **standard excess of £250** per policy.
- Claims are paid by your insurer and then reimbursed by Flood Re.
- **Eligibility:** individual policyholders; owner or immediate family lives there (or it is unoccupied); domestic **Council Tax band A–H**; private residential; a single unit or a building of **no more than 3 units**; individually insured; **built before 1 January 2009**; in England, Wales, Scotland or Northern Ireland. It excludes blocks of more than three flats, housing association buildings and business-rated premises.
- **Build Back Better:** up to **£10,000** for flood-resistance and resilience measures on top of repairs, if your insurer offers it. [2]

Event	Home and contents	Notes
Flood	Usually covered, and Flood Re supports high-risk homes	Check your policy; Flood Re eligibility rules above
Storm	Normally covered	Check the policy wording and excess
Terrorism	Household policies normally cover terrorism	**Pool Re** covers **commercial** property, backed by an unlimited government guarantee
War	Normally **excluded**	War exclusions are standard. [VERIFY]
Nuclear	Normally **excluded**	Standard nuclear exclusion. [VERIFY]
Pandemic	Business interruption generally not covered	Some policies offer extensions

Pool Re was established in 1993 after reinsurers withdrew from terrorism cover. It is a mutual reinsurer providing members with an **unlimited government guarantee** to insure commercial property against terrorist acts. A 2022 strategic review cut overall pricing by **20%** and extended the guarantee by a further **five years**. [3]

G.5 Government compensation

- **Bellwin scheme** (England): discretionary emergency financial assistance to local authorities, under s.155 of the Local Government and Housing Act 1989. It reimburses eligible spending above a threshold set at **0.2%** of the authority's calculated annual budget. Eligible spending includes safeguarding life and property, rest centres, evacuation and bed-and-breakfast costs, temporary mortuaries and emergency food supplies. **Insurable costs are excluded.** [4]
- **Flood Recovery Framework** (England): activated at ministerial discretion for wide-area severe weather. Core schemes include a **Community Recovery Grant** (around **£500** per household), a **Business Recovery Grant** (around **£2,500** per SME), **100% council tax discount** for at least three months, and **100% business rates relief** for at least three months for properties with a rateable value under **£10 million**. [5]
- **Storm Henk (January 2024) payments** illustrate the scale: up to **£500** for flooded households, up to **£2,500** for SMEs, up to **£5,000** from the Property Flood Resilience Repair Grant, up to **£25,000** from the Farming Recovery Fund, plus council tax and business rates relief. [6]
- **Always claim on insurance first.** Government schemes generally exclude damage that is insurable.

G.6 Documenting damage

1. **Photograph everything before you move or clean anything** — every room, every item.
2. Keep receipts for emergency repairs, accommodation and replacement items.
3. Keep a written timeline: when the incident happened, when you evacuated, who you spoke to.
4. Report to your insurer as soon as you can; keep the claim reference.
5. Keep damaged items for inspection unless they are a health hazard.
6. Register with your council — this is how you access recovery grants.

Notes

1. https://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukpga/2004/36/contents — Civil Contingencies Act 2004; see also the Emergency Powers Act 1920 (repealed), the Coronavirus Act 2020, the Public Order Act 1986 and 2023, PACE 1984, the Terrorism Act 2000 and the Counter-Terrorism and Border Security Act 2019. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
2. https://www.floodre.co.uk/how-flood-re-works/ — Flood Re: scheme running to 2039; £160 million annual Levy; fixed premium by council tax band; standard £250 excess; claims paid by the insurer and reimbursed; Build Back Better up to £10,000. Eligibility (band A–H, built before 1 January 2009, up to 3 units, private residential, individually insured) from https://www.floodre.co.uk/faq_categories/eligibility/. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
3. https://www.gov.uk/government/news/pool-re-to-offer-cheaper-premiums-and-unlimited-guarantee-extended — Pool Re, established 1993, provides members with an unlimited government guarantee for commercial terrorism cover; the strategic review cut pricing by 20% and extended the guarantee by five years. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
4. https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/bellwin-scheme-guidance-notes-for-claims/bellwin-scheme-of-emergency-financial-assistance-to-local-authorities-guidance-notes-for-claims — Bellwin scheme under s.155 Local Government and Housing Act 1989; threshold 0.2% of the calculated annual budget; eligible costs include rest centres, evacuation and B&B, temporary mortuaries and emergency food; insurable costs excluded. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
5. https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/flood-recovery-framework-guidance-for-local-authorities-in-england/flood-recovery-framework-guidance-for-local-authorities-in-england — Community Recovery Grant (~£500), Business Recovery Grant (~£2,500), 100% council tax discount and business rates relief for at least 3 months (rateable value under £10 million). Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑
6. https://www.gov.uk/government/news/government-payments-for-communities-affected-by-flooding — Storm Henk payments: up to £500 per household, £2,500 per SME, £5,000 Property Flood Resilience Repair Grant, £25,000 Farming Recovery Fund, plus rates and council tax relief. Retrieved 2026-10-26. ↑

H. CHECKLISTS (printable)

H.1 Household preparedness

- [ ] 3 days of water (3 litres per person per day) and non-perishable food
- [ ] Torch, spare batteries, blankets, warm clothing
- [ ] Battery or wind-up FM radio with frequencies written down
- [ ] Charged power bank
- [ ] Cash: coins and notes
- [ ] Printed copies of ID, birth certificates, insurance, medical instructions
- [ ] Written contact list and medication list
- [ ] First aid kit
- [ ] Baby formula and nappies, or pet food and water, if relevant
- [ ] Household emergency plan written and discussed

- [ ] Meeting points agreed (near home, outside the area)
- [ ] Out-of-area contact agreed
- [ ] Know how to turn off gas, electricity and water
- [ ] Smoke alarms tested monthly
- [ ] Priority Services Register checked
- [ ] Check and refresh the kit every six months

H.2 Emergency kit

- [ ] Water — 3 litres per person per day for 3 days
- [ ] Non-perishable food for 3 days
- [ ] Tin opener
- [ ] Hand sanitiser, wet wipes, bathroom products
- [ ] Torch and spare batteries
- [ ] Blankets, sleeping bags, warm clothing
- [ ] Battery or wind-up FM radio
- [ ] Power bank
- [ ] Cash and cards
- [ ] Document copies
- [ ] Contact and medication lists
- [ ] First aid kit
- [ ] Essential medication
- [ ] Baby and pet supplies

H.3 Grab bag

- [ ] Documents and cash
- [ ] Medication and medication list
- [ ] Water and snack food
- [ ]

- [ ] Torch and batteries
- [ ] Radio
- [ ] Power bank and cable
- [ ] Warm clothing and waterproofs
- [ ] First aid kit
- [ ] Phone charger

H.4 Shelter in place

- [ ] Go inside — any building other than the one involved
- [ ] Close external doors and windows
- [ ] Shut off fans and air conditioning
- [ ] Close air vents, including trickle vents
- [ ] Move away from windows
- [ ] Radio on
- [ ] Do not collect children from school
- [ ] Do not evacuate unless told
- [ ] Stay in until officially told it is safe

H.5 Evacuation

- [ ] Instruction confirmed via Emergency Alert, police or radio
- [ ] Gas, electricity and water off if safe
- [ ] Grab bag, medication, documents, cash, phone and charger taken
- [ ] Windows and doors closed and locked
- [ ] Note left saying where you have gone
- [ ] Neighbours who need help assisted
- [ ] Pets taken, or alternative arrangement confirmed
- [ ] Registered at the rest centre

H.6 After the event

- [ ] Safety checked: gas, electricity, structural damage
- [ ] Injuries and vulnerable people dealt with
- [ ] Damage photographed before cleaning
- [ ] Insurer and council contacted
- [ ] Food and water checked; spoiled food discarded
- [ ] Medication checked
- [ ] Mental health support considered
- [ ] Kit restocked and batteries replaced

H.7 Scenario quick-cards

Scenario	First action	Key resource
Flooding	Move up; act on the flood warning	Radio, water, grab bag, 999 if trapped
Coastal flooding	Evacuate when told; never drive through water	Rest centre, Floodline
Severe weather	Red warning: stay in	Met Office app, 105 for power cuts
Wildfire	Leave early, move across the fire’s path	999, radio
Power cut	Report on 105; unplug appliances	Torch, radio, cash, blankets
Telecoms failure	Text rather than call; listen to radio	Paper numbers, community hub
Water loss	Use stored water; follow do-not-drink notices	3 litres/person/day, bottled-water points
Food and fuel shortage	Ration; do not hoard	Stored food, community hub
Pandemic	Follow public health guidance	111, NHS, UKHSA
Chemical release	Go in, stay in, tune in	Tape, vents, radio
Radiation	Go in, stay in, tune in; iodine only if told	Radio, iodine if eligible
Cyber attack	Do not pay; disconnect; report	NCSC, Action Fraud, cash
Terrorism	Run, Hide, Tell	999, exits
Armed conflict	Go in, stay in, tune in	Shelter, 3–7 days of supplies
Transport accident	Get clear; report to responders	999, reception centre
Mass evacuation	Leave when told; register	Grab bag, rest centre
Reservoir failure	Move to higher ground immediately	Radio, local knowledge
Space weather	Expect power, telecoms and GPS loss	Radio, paper maps
Drought and heat	Follow restrictions; keep cool	Water, cool spaces
Animal disease	Obey movement restrictions	Official notices

APPENDICES

Appendix 1 — Glossary and abbreviations

Term	Meaning
AAIB	Air Accidents Investigation Branch
A&E / ED	Accident and emergency / emergency department
Bellwin	Scheme reimbursing local authorities for emergency costs
CCA	Civil Contingencies Act 2004
CHEMET	Met Office chemical meteorology service
COBR	Cabinet Office Briefing Rooms — cross-government crisis meeting ("COBRA")
COMAH	Control of Major Accident Hazards Regulations 2015
CRR	Community Risk Register — the local risk register
DCLG / MHCLG	Former housing and communities departments
Defra	Department for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs
DESNZ	Department for Energy Security and Net Zero
DHSC	Department of Health and Social Care
DNO	Distribution Network Operator
EA	Environment Agency
EPG	Emergency Preparedness Group (Northern Ireland)
Flood Re	Flood reinsurance scheme for UK households
HSE	Health and Safety Executive
JCVI	Joint Committee on Vaccination and Immunisation
JTAC	Joint Terrorism Analysis Centre
LGD	Lead Government Department
LRF	Local Resilience Forum
MACA	Military Aid to the Civil Authorities
MAIB	Marine Accident Investigation Branch
MTC	Major Trauma Centre
NESO	National Energy System Operator
NIS	Network and Information Systems Regulations
NRR	National Risk Register
NSRA	National Security Risk Assessment
ONR	Office for Nuclear Regulation
PACE	Police and Criminal Evidence Act 1984
PHE / UKHSA	Public Health England (abolished) / UK Health Security Agency
Pool Re	Terrorism reinsurer for commercial property
PSR	Priority Services Register
RAIB	Rail Accident Investigation Branch
REPPIR	Radiation (Emergency Preparedness and Public Information) Regulations 2019
RRP	Regional Resilience Partnership (Scotland)
UKHSA	UK Health Security Agency

Appendix 2 — Key phrases

The UK's emergency advice in plain terms:

Phrase	Meaning
Go in, stay in, tune in	Get inside, stay inside, listen to local radio or TV
Run, Hide, Tell	Flee if you can, hide if you cannot, tell the police when safe
Remove, remove, remove	Leave the area, remove outer clothing, then wash — for chemical contamination
Be ready for 3 days	Keep three days of supplies
Make a plan	Write down meeting points, contacts and what to do

Appendix 3 — Contact directory

Organisation	Number	When
Emergency services	**999** or **112**	Immediate danger to life
Police non-emergency	**101**	Non-urgent crime and concern
NHS urgent care	**111**	Urgent medical help that is not an emergency
Power cut	**105**	England, Scotland, Wales
Power cut (NI)	**03457 643643**	Northern Ireland
Gas emergency	**0800 111 999**	Smell of gas
Environment Agency incident hotline	**0800 80 70 60**	Pollution, river flooding, dead animals
Floodline	**0345 988 1188**	Flood warnings and advice (textphone 0345 602 6340)
Samaritans	**116 123**	Emotional support, 24/7
Samaritans (Welsh)	**0808 164 0123**	Welsh-language support
Childline	**0800 1111**	Under-19s
Cruse Bereavement Support	**0808 808 1677**	Bereavement
Lifeline (NI)	**0808 808 8000**	Northern Ireland crisis line
NHS 111 text relay	**18001 111**	Text relay for 111

Appendix 4 — Radio

- **BBC Radio 4** on FM — national news and emergency information.
- **BBC local radio** in England — county-level information and travel.
- **BBC Radio Scotland**, **Radio Wales**, **Radio Cymru**, **Radio Ulster / Foyle** — devolved nations.
- **BBC Radio 5 Live** — rolling news.
- **Commercial and community radio** — local information.

Write the frequencies for your area on your radio now. A **battery or wind-up FM radio** is part of the official kit, precisely because Emergency Alerts and the internet may fail together. [5]

Appendix 5 — Sources

Every source is listed in the numbered notes at the end of each chapter, with its retrieval date (**26 October 2026** unless stated otherwise). This appendix is an **index** into those lists rather than a second copy, so the same source never exists in two versions.

Chapter	Subject	Sources	Notes
A	Quick reference: alerts, numbers, radio	5	end of part A
B	Civil contingencies, NRR, responders, military, law	14	end of part B
C	Scenarios	36	end of part C
D–H	Locations, reserves, preparedness, law, checklists	see chapter notes	end of each chapter

Primary sources used (full citations and dates in the notes):

- **Cabinet Office / GOV.UK** — Civil Contingencies Act 2004, National Risk Register 2026, Emergency Alerts, Be Ready campaign, Flood Recovery Framework, Bellwin scheme guidance, Evacuation and Shelter Guidance.
- **Legislation** — legislation.gov.uk: CCA 2004, REPPIR 2019, COMAH 2015, Pipelines Safety Regulations 1996.
- **Environment Agency** — flood warnings and levels, Floodline, flood planning.
- **Met Office** — weather warnings, CHEMET, space weather.
- **HSE** — COMAH and pipelines; **ONR** — nuclear sites and emergency arrangements.
- **NHS England / UKHSA / devolved public health** — emergency care, stockpiles, pandemic planning.
- **ONS** — COVID-19 mortality.
- **Flood Re / Pool Re** — insurance schemes.

Appendix 6 — Change log

Version	Date	Change
0.1	2026-10-26	First draft: structure, core facts, sources.

Appendix 7 — How to update this document

1. **Every 6 months:** phone numbers, radio frequencies, insurance schemes, priority registers.
2. **Every year:** legislation, the National Risk Register (now updated dynamically), Local Resilience Forum risk registers.
3. **On change:** edit the Markdown, bump `VERSION`, add a row to Appendix 6, rebuild.
4. **Build:** `./build.sh` produces a versioned PDF and ZIM from this Markdown.
5. **Print** part A separately and keep it with your kit.

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